THE HUNGER GAMES: CATCHING FIRE

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Based on the novel by
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EXT. WOODS - DAWN

Silence. A sublime landscape of fog and trees.

Katniss Everdeen sits silently, her bow ready.

ECU -- Her eyes. Haunted. A thousand yard stare.

GALE (O.S.)
Katniss...

She spins -- panicked, terrified -- aiming right at Gale Hawthorne, approaching from behind. He lifts his hands.

GALE (CONT'D)
Whoa-- easy-- Don't shoot.

She recovers -- exhaling. Lowers her bow. He smiles.

GALE (CONT'D)
Not yet, anyway.

He approaches, amused, unslings his bow, checks his arrows, readying for the hunt. Her eyes take him in.

GALE (CONT'D)
Saw a bunch of turkeys on the way, crossed right in front of me. Like I wasn't even there.

KATNISS
How rude of them.

GALE
That's what happens, you spend six days a week workin' in the mine. Stupid birds start to think they own these woods.

She grins. He finishes his prep, gives her a look.

GALE (CONT'D)
When's the tour leave?

KATNISS
Couple of hours.

They share a look. He turns.

GALE
Better get started.

EXT. WOODS - EARLY MORNING

Katniss and Gale hunt together. They share the easy intimacy of many years doing this. The morning woods are beautiful. They check traps, gather game, re-set traps.

Absorbed in hunting, Katniss loses the worry in her face. It's as close to happy as she gets. Gale lets her lead, so he can gaze at her. We see his love and longing.

EXT. WOODED GLADE - LATER

Katniss and Gale walk through a glade, belts carrying a couple of rabbits, a few grouse, etc. Katniss raises a hand. Gale looks at her. She nods into the distance. A flock of turkeys is waddling through dappled sunlight.

Gale and Katniss share a glance. She lifts her bow. A male turkey lifts its head. Katniss takes careful aim. Katniss shoots. Suddenly, it is Marvel -- the boy from District One -- who gets an arrow through the neck.

Katniss CRIES OUT, drops her bow and un-shot arrow, coming out of her flashback. She turns away from Gale -- trembling, upset. He goes and tries to comfort her.

GALE
It's okay, you're safe, you're right here... with me...

He touches her but she pulls away. Slowly -- on her own -- she pulls herself together. All he can do is watch. Finally, she turns -- under control but still fragile.

KATNISS
We better go.

EXT. WOODS - DAY

Katniss and Gale hide their bows and arrows in the hollow of a tree.

EXT. FENCE - DAY

Snow is falling lightly. Katniss and Gale approach the rusty fence surrounding the town. It's not electrified. They duck under. Below, we see the layout of District 12.

EXT. DIRT ROAD - DAY

Katniss and Gale walk down a road, carrying their game. Snow mixes with mud. Behind in the distance, giant industrial mining machinery with a Capitol logo looms.

Coming the other way is a troupe of MINERS, blanketed in coal dust. Gaunt, weary. A few YOUNG MINERS among them. They pass without acknowledgement. Katniss catches a look -- envy? Resentment? -- from a young GIRL MINER.

WIDE -- They pass a large billboard: an illustration of a troupe of clean, healthy, smiling miners walking forward, united. It reads, "Working For A Better Tomorrow".

EXT. THE HOB - DAY

They approach the Hob. Shacks dot the muddy path. Wood boards have been laid to span boggy puddles. Dirty-faced CHILDREN and weathered MOTHERS peer out of wood doorways.

INT. THE HOB - DAY

Morning bustle. Katniss watches as Gale chats with Greasy Sae, trading small game for various sundries. An old woman, RIPPER, puts a couple of small bottles of moonshine on her stall counter. Katniss hands her a coin.

RIPPER
Don't pay with chipmunks anymore, do ya?

They trade smiles. Katniss turns, pocketing the bottles.

EXT. ALLEY BEHIND THE HOB - DAY

Katniss and Gale stand in the alley. She doesn't notice him checking to make sure they are alone.

KATNISS
You coming to the station?

GALE
I think you'll have plenty enough people saying goodbye without me there.

KATNISS
Only a few I care about.

GALE
Still. Might be easier if I didn't.

KATNISS
It's only a month. I'll be back before the snow melts.

GALE
A lot can happen in a month.

She gets the meaning of that, stops and turns to him.

KATNISS
We going to do this again?

He looks around, anywhere, but directly at her. She shakes her head frustrated, then--

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Gale. It was an act.

GALE
Was a good one.

She looks at him -- why's he being this way?

KATNISS
I did what I did to survive. I had to. If I didn't, I'd be dead.

He finally nods, steps forward.

GALE
I know...

And before she knows it, he takes her face in his hands, kisses her.

She is surprised. She kisses back but her hands stay by her side. He breaks away. She looks at him, stunned.

GALE (CONT'D)
And I had to do that. At least once.

He looks at her, turns and walks off. Suddenly self-conscious, she looks around. No one was watching.

EXT. VICTOR'S VILLAGE, GATE - DAY

Katniss walks along a garden path by the entrance gate. A sign reads, "Victor's Village".

At a fountain, Buttercup is lapping water from a break in the ice. The cat turns, HISSES at her. She hisses back.

KATNISS
Like I care.

EXT. HAYMITCH'S HOUSE, VICTOR'S VILLAGE - DAY

Katniss knocks on the front door. Left slightly ajar, it swings open slightly. From inside comes SNORING.

INT. HAYMITCH'S HOUSE - DAY

Katniss steps into a grimy kitchen. Haymitch is snoring, face on the table, empty bottles and a glass by his side.

KATNISS
Haymitch. Wake up. Tour Day.

She nudges him. Nothing. Shakes him. She steps back and looks at him, empathy on her face. Then she turns.

QUICK CUTS -- The stove is lit. Coffee is made. A jug filled with water.

Katniss pours the jug over Haymitch's head. With a roar, he comes to life, flailing a knife, knocking over empty bottles.

HAYMITCH
What are you doing?

KATNISS
You told me to wake you--

She leaps out of his way onto the window sill.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Cameras'll be here in an hour!

He looks down at himself.

HAYMITCH
Why am I wet?

KATNISS
(shrugs)
You wouldn't wake up.

He makes a move for her, but she kicks the table over from her perch, blocking him. He looks at her.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
If you want to be babied, you should've asked Peeta.

PEETA (O.S.)
Asked me what?

They turn. Peeta steps in, holding two loaves of bread. Katniss watches as Peeta now rights the table. He's now stronger, looks healthy, a bit of snow in his hair.

HAYMITCH
Asked you to wake me without giving me pneumonia.

Haymitch slides his knife over to Peeta, points a finger at Katniss.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
You are a strangely dislikable person.

She takes out the little bottles of moonshine and sets them on the counter.

KATNISS
From Ripper.

HAYMITCH
(opening one)
But you do have your virtues.

Peeta wipes the blade on his shirttail, starts to slice the bread. He gives a piece to Haymitch and now, for the first time since he's walked in, looks at Katniss.

PEETA
Would you like some?

KATNISS
No. I ate at the Hob.
(then)
But thank you.

PEETA
You're welcome.

Haymitch turns and watches the awkward, uneasy glance between Peeta and Katniss.

HAYMITCH
Brrr. You two got a lot of warming up to do before show time.

He takes a long pull of the moonshine. She forces a smile at Peeta--

KATNISS
Guess I'll see you later.

He nods. She pivots on the sill, looks over her shoulder--

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Take a bath, Haymitch.

And like that, she's out the window.

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DAY

Through a window, we SEE Katniss approaching up the walk. ANGLE -- Katniss comes through the door to be confronted by her Mother, anxiety on her face, and Prim behind her.

MOTHER
You have a good walk?

KATNISS
(puzzled)
I've been out with --

PRIM
-- We've got visitors!

A Presidential Guard appears from behind them.

PRESIDENTIAL GUARD
Miss Everdeen? This way.

INT./EXT. STUDY - DAY

The Guard opens the door, waves her in. The door shuts. Someone is sitting in a chair, his back to her, watching a re-run of the 74th Hunger Games on the TV. The final moments of Katniss and Peeta holding the poison berries.

SNOW
Such bravery. Spirit. Such...

The frame freezes. The man spins around. President Snow. Cup of tea in his hand. White rose in his lapel. Katniss is frozen with terror.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Contempt?

KATNISS
President Snow. What an honor.

Snow smiles at this, puts down his tea.

SNOW
My dear. We'll make this simpler if we agree not to lie to each other. What do you think?

KATNISS
Yes, I think that would save time.

He considers her a moment, then--

SNOW
My advisors were concerned you'd be difficult. But you're not planning on being difficult, are you?

KATNISS
No.

SNOW
That's what I told them. I said any girl who goes to--
(looks at the TV)
--such lengths to preserve her life won't be interested in throwing it away.
(turns back to her)
And then there's her family to think of.

She looks at him. The word "family" hanging there, bringing her a chill. He smiles.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Please. Sit down.

He sits down at the old desk. She across from him.

SNOW (CONT'D)
I have a problem, Miss Everdeen. A problem that began the moment you revealed those poison berries in the arena.

She says nothing, shows him nothing.

SNOW (CONT'D)
If the head Gamemaker, Seneca Crane, had had any brains he'd have blown you to dust, then and there, but he had an unfortunate sentimental streak, so here you are.
(sits back)
I expect you can guess where he is?

KATNISS
I think so.

SNOW
After that fiasco there was nothing left to do but let you play out your little scenario. And you were very good, that whole love crazed besotted schoolgirl routine. Impressive. You convinced the people in the Capitol.
(then)
Unfortunately, not everyone in the districts fell for it.

He sees the question in her face.

SNOW (CONT'D)
You don't know but in several of them, people viewed your little trick with the berries as an act of defiance, not an act of love. And if a girl from District 12, of all places, can defy the Capitol and walk away unharmed, what is to prevent them from doing the same - what is to prevent, say, an uprising...?

her stiffen, smiles.

SNOW (CONT'D)
That word gives you pause. Me, too. Uprising. They've been known to lead to revolutions. And then, in a mere fraction of time, the whole system collapses.

KATNISS
Must be a fragile system if it can be brought down by a few berries.

back, amused by her impudence.

SNOW
But it is indeed, though not in the way you imagine.

KATNISS
How should I imagine?

He is suddenly deadly serious.

SNOW
You should imagine thousands upon thousands of people dead. This town of yours reduced to ash. Imagine it gone. Made radioactive, and then buried in the dirt as if it never existed.
(then)
Like District 13.

Any courage she had a moment ago, is now gone.

SNOW (CONT'D)
You fought hard in the games, Miss Everdeen, but they were just games. Would you like to be in a real war.

KATNISS
No.

He looks at her. Sees she understands.

SNOW
Good. Neither would I.

He gets up, moves to where a plate of frosted cookies sits on the tea tray. She says to his back...

KATNISS
I never meant to start any... uprisings.

SNOW
Oh, I believe you. But it doesn't matter, now does it?

He turns, his black gloved hand holding up a cookie in his handkerchief.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Your mother made these...?

KATNISS
Peeta.

SNOW
(he smiles)
Lovely boy. So talented. Tell me, at what point did he realize the depth of your indifference to him?

KATNISS
I'm not indifferent.

SNOW
(a cautionary finger)
Please. You promised. No lying.

Snow dips the cookie in his cup of tea, takes a bite.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Mmm, delicious! People forget that a President needs to eat.

KATNISS
Why don't you just kill me now?

He looks at her, chewing on the cookie, as if he's actually considering it, or has considered it. Finally--

SNOW
I don't want to kill you.

He keeps looking at her. Offers her a cookie...

SNOW (CONT'D)
I want us to be friends.
(she doesn't take it)
Or if not friends, at least allies. Why not? We already have so much in common.

KATNISS
Such as?

SNOW
Both of us are the sort who will do whatever's necessary to get what we want. Whatever's necessary to win.

KATNISS
What do I need to do?

SNOW
When you and Peeta are on tour, you will smile, you will be grateful... but above all, you will be in love. Madly, prepared-to-end-it-all in love.
(MORE)

SNOW (CONT'D)
You will be a love-struck girl who didn't know what she was doing. Who was just following her heart. Do you think you can manage that?

KATNISS
Yes.

SNOW
Yes, what?

KATNISS
I'll convince them.

Snow leans in close, his eyes without artifice of any kind.

SNOW
Aim higher, convince *me*.

Snow hands her the rose, stands. Passing the TV, he flicks a button. On the screen is a telephoto shot of Katniss and Gale, in the woods behind the Hob. Katniss is stunned. Snow gets to the door, turns back.

SNOW (CONT'D)
For the sake of your loved ones.

He exits. Katniss exhales deeply. Suddenly, she is trembling. She turns, looks at Gale kiss her on the TV.

EXT. VICTOR'S VILLAGE - DAY

In the background, lights and cameras are being set up. Into FRAME steps EFFIE TRINKET. She exhales -- the returning queen.

EFFIE
Just look at it, would you? This is... sacred ground. History was made on this site.

Octavia and Flavius step up behind her. Look doubtful. Effie glances back.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
You get used to the smell.

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DAY

Katniss comes down the stairs as her Mother is letting in Effie, followed by Flavius and Octavia. Effie, in an orange wig, sees Katniss and opens her arms...

EFFIE
And there she is. My greatest triumph!

The others look at her, see the weariness in her face, try to pump up the energy. But it's forced--

OCTAVIA
The Girl on Fire!

FLAVIUS
Our little superstar!

They swarm over her -- hugging, air-kissing, examining. She lets herself be caught up in their warm affection. Octavia gives her the once-over, gasps.

OCTAVIA
Oh, dear God--

KATNISS
What's wrong?

OCTAVIA
Your eyebrows! And you promised not to touch your hair... and--
(grabs her hand)
--and what do you cut your nails with? A butcher knife?!

FLAVIUS
Leave her alone! Sweetie, we've missed you!

Katniss smiles, but Effie sees there's not a lot in it. She knows what might cheer her up--

EFFIE
Of course you've heard about Cinna?

KATNISS
What happened?

EFFIE
What *happened?* You're his muse! How could you not know? He's a fashion God. He's changed everything! Everyone wants to wear his clothes!

CINNA (O.C.)
Not everyone.

They turn as Cinna walks in. Katniss smiles warmly.

KATNISS
Hey, Cinna.

CINNA
Don't listen to these two. You look beautiful.

They embrace.

PRIM
Katniss...?

They all turn. Prim, shy, peaks in, holding Buttercup.

OCTAVIA
Katniss? Is this your sister?!

Before she can answer, they're on Prim. Fawning... *You're adorable! I can see why you volunteered for her! Sweetie, I could eat you with a spoon!*

Prim basks in the attention. Cinna turns to Katniss.

CINNA
You okay?

She hesitates, nods. He studies her, then--

CINNA (CONT'D)
Good.

He tosses a bundle of clothes at her feet.

CINNA (CONT'D)
Time to go to work.

INT. CAPITOL STUDIO - DUSK - TV SHOW

Caesar Flickerman sits in a studio. Victory Tour GRAPHICS and PHOTOS of Katniss and Peeta.

CAESAR
...And now the moment comes! Are they still together? Have they broken up? Are they fighting yet? Can true love survive outside the Arena? For all the details...

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DUSK - CONTINUOUS

Crowded. Effie stands with Katniss just behind the front door. Cinna helps Katniss into a fur coat. The Prep Team hovers, doing touch ups. The TV plays in a corner.

CAESAR (TV)
...Let's go to District Twelve as the star-crossed lovers embark on Day One of their Victory Tour!

EFFIE
Enough, people! Time to feed the monster! Big smiles! Big smiles! We're happy and excited!

INT./EXT. KATNISS'S HOUSE / FRONT YARD - DUSK

Katniss pushes out her front door, into a blinding blaze of TV lighting. A pair of drone-crane TV cameras glide in on her. Caesar Flickerman's voice BOOMS over a P.A.

CAESAR (O.C.)
And here she is: Katniss Everdeen!

Down the street, Peeta steps from his house, sees her. His stylist, PORTIA, and her ASSISTANT stand off-camera.

CAESAR (O.C.) (CONT'D)
And here he is: Peeta Mellark!

Peeta sees Katniss and walks down the steps toward her. She smiles and comes down her steps toward him. The CAMERA DRONES glide along with her. Katniss throws her arms around Peeta. He slips and they fall over laughing.

CAESAR (O.C.) (CONT'D)
Whoa! Trouble in paradise!

Close on Katniss, she kisses Peeta. Peeta returns it.

PULL BACK TO REVEAL: THE ACTION IS HAPPENING ON A TV

CAESAR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
My goodness, look at them! What an utterly sweet moment!

Someone SHUTS IT OFF. And we see GALE REFLECTED IN THE SCREEN. Continue pulling back to reveal we're inside:

INT. GALE'S HOUSE - DUSK

On TV, Katniss kisses Peeta. Gale watches the TV, alone. He looks away -- not able to bear it.

INT. CAPITOL STUDIO - MOMENTS LATER

Caesar interviews Katniss and Peeta on a huge screen. Off the pair, still lip-locked...

CAESAR
(to audience)
Well, I guess that answers our first question.
(to Katniss and Peeta)
So, Katniss? Peeta?
(beat)
Should we come back later?

Katniss and Peeta break apart, grinning happily at the camera.

PEETA (TV)
No, now's good.

KATNISS (TV)
Sorry, Caesar.

They stand up, laughing and brushing the snow off each other.

CAESAR
Don't be. This is *your* day. So... how are you two?

PEETA (TV)
We're good.

CAESAR
Come on, Peeta. Seriously, give us some details.

Katniss and Peeta exchange a look. Smile.

PEETA (TV)
Things are great here in Twelve.

KATNISS (TV)
Thanks to the generosity of the Capitol, we've never been closer.

PEETA (TV)
A hundred yards to be exact.

Katniss bats him playfully. Canned LAUGHTER.

EXT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DUSK

Katniss and Peeta hold hands and face blinding lights and the unblinking gaze of the cameras. Caesar's voice BOOMS.

CAESAR (V.O.)
Fantastic! We'll be checking in with you throughout the Victory Tour. Ladies and gentlemen, Katniss and Peeta!

We HEAR canned APPLAUSE through the PA. Katniss and Peeta smile, kiss, and wave happily and the CAMERA DRONE tracks in close. Effie is just off camera, pantomiming.

EFFIE
Smiling... smiling... we're happy and in love!

Film lights abruptly switch off. The Camera drones droop. Immediately, Effie turns, begins hustling the next move.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
All right, we're out of here in ten. Everybody in motion. We're on a schedule, my children!
(as she exits)
The train awaits!

as the camera's off, the smile drops from Peeta's face. He turns, with strained politeness.

PEETA
Nice acting.

KATNISS
You too.

PEETA
Almost thought that kiss was real. But I made that mistake already.

He turns, walks off. She watches him go as...

EFFIE (V.O.)
You two are so lucky...

EXT. TRAIN - MORNING - ESTABLISHING SHOT

The train flies across the countryside.

EFFIE (V.O.)
Fabulous food! Fabulous wine...!

INT. TRAIN, DINING CAR - MORNING

Breakfast. Katniss, Peeta, Haymitch, Effie and the Prep Teams. Katniss is poking at her food. Haymitch is quietly getting drunk. Effie is trying -- in her own way -- to convey her pride and affection for Katniss and Peeta.

EFFIE
Massages! Spa treatments! I said nothing but the best for my two victors! It all has to be just...

Searches for the right word. Haymitch doesn't look up.

HAYMITCH
Fabulous.

EFFIE
Exactly! Now, the schedule's a bit of a killer -- twelve days, twelve districts. But... it's all parties, celebrations and adoring fans to greet you at every stop! Then we wrap it up in the Capitol!

Katniss looks up. Reminded of her visit with Snow. Effie misinterprets her apprehension...

EFFIE (CONT'D)
All you need to do is give a teeny little speech, wave to the crowds, and then sit back and enjoy your time in the spotlight. After all, you've earned it!

Katniss looks back at her incredulous.

KATNISS
What did you say?

PEETA
Katniss--

She holds up a hand, quieting him. Looks at Effie.

EFFIE
I say enjoy your time in the spotlight! You earned it!

KATNISS
By *killing people.*

She turns, disgusted, and exits. The table is shocked.

EFFIE
Poor thing is just exhausted.

INT. TRAIN, CORRIDOR - MORNING

Katniss stalks through the train. She passes a doorway as a Peacekeeper exits and walks past her. She stops.

Inside a compartment is the security center. Peacekeepers sit at banks of monitors. Some monitors show the train, but others are labeled "District 12", "District 11", etc.

Katniss stares. She's never seen anything like this. Another Peacekeeper notices her. The door slides shut.

INT. TRAIN, OBSERVATION DECK - MORNING

Katniss stands on the rear deck, which now rolls slowly through green fields. She gazes at her Mockingjay pin, in her hand, puts it away. A shadow steps next to her.

KATNISS
I'm not in the mood for a lecture. I'll apologize to Effie later--

She turns. It's Peeta. They are awkward.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I thought you were Haymitch.

PEETA
You don't owe <u>anybody</u> an apology.
(then)
Including me.

She looks at him.

PEETA (CONT'D)
It's not fair of me to hold you to things you said in the Games. You saved our lives. I know that. But I can't go on like this: acting for the cameras, then ignoring each other in real life.

She nods. She can't either.

PEETA (CONT'D)
So if you promise to quit looking at me like I'm so... *wounded*, I promise to quit acting like it.

She smiles.

PEETA (CONT'D)
Then maybe, just maybe, we could take a shot at just being friends.

She looks at him -- taken by his honesty and decency.

KATNISS
I'm not too good at friends.

PEETA
For starters, it helps if you know each other.
(off her look)
I don't know anything about you other than you're stubborn and you're halfway decent with a bow.

KATNISS
(smiles)
That about sums me up.

PEETA
Not hardly. You just don't want to tell me anything.

KATNISS
Like I said--

PEETA
(moving right along)
See, the way the whole fiend thing works, friends tell each other the, you know, the deep stuff.

KATNISS
Deep stuff? Uh oh. Like what?

PEETA
Like... what's your favorite color?

KATNISS
Now you've stepped over the line.

They both smile. A moment where they just look out. Then--

PEETA
Seriously. What is it?

KATNISS
(thinks, then)
Green. Yours?

PEETA
Orange.

KATNISS
(nods)
Like Effie's hair.

PEETA
Not that orange.
(then)
More... like the sunset.

KATNISS
Okay. Green and Orange.

PEETA
See. Wasn't so hard, was it?

She smiles. A HORN. The train slows. She sees something over his shoulder. He turns. The train approaches gates that say "Welcome to District 11".

KATNISS
Looks like we're here.

They go into a tunnel -- darkness broken by FLASHES of electrical sparking. Katniss sees a flash of graffiti. The Mockingjay symbol. Her head whips around.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Did you see that?

PEETA
What?

She can't say it. Shakes her head.

KATNISS
Nothing.

They exit the tunnel. The District 11 side of the fence is much more heavily armed and guarded -- multiple gates, more Peacekeepers, razor wire, machine guns, bunkers. It's a state in lockdown -- martial law. Katniss catches her breath, turns to Peeta. He returns her worried gaze. They've never seen anything like this.

EXT. STATION, DISTRICT 11 - DAY

Peeta, Katniss Haymitch and the stylist Team get down from the train. Empty platform. Instead of the cheering masses, armed Peacekeepers hustle them into waiting cars.

EFFIE
Not very festive at all, is it? You'd think we're all criminals!

EXT. DISTRICT 11 COUNTRYSIDE, MOTORCADE - DAY

A military motorcade speeds through a countryside of wheat fields. Men, women and children in the fields, harvesting. Behind them stand Peacekeepers with guns.

EFFIE (V.O.)
The mayor will do the talking. You just need to say a few words...

INT./EXT. DISTRICT 11 CAR - DAY

Effie runs thru her clipboard check list. Katniss gazes out the window as the motorcade speeds down a highway.

EFFIE
...It's customary to offer a brief eulogy to the fallen tributes. For Eleven that means Thresh and Rue. Here are your speeches.

Effie offers Peeta and Katniss a stack of cue cards. Katniss looks up, alarmed. Peeta takes the cards.

PEETA
I'll do the talking, if you want.

Their eyes meet. She gives him a grateful look.

MAYOR (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen, the Victors of the 74th Hunger Games...

INT./EXT. JUSTICE BUILDING, ROTUNDA - DAY

Katniss and Peeta stand before a giant set of French doors. Through the doors, we can SEE the Mayor, on the veranda, making a speech, his amplified voice ECHOING.

MAYOR
...Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark!

The Anthem begins to play. The doors to the veranda open, revealing a vast CROWD. Effie urges them forward.

EFFIE
Smile smile, wave wave wave... we're so excited to be here!

EXT. TOWN SQUARE, DISTRICT 11 - CONTINUOUS

Peeta and Katniss walk onto a stage, smiling and waving like pros. Respectful applause from the crowd.

INT. JUSTICE BUILDING, BACK-STAGE - DAY

In a dilapidated room behind the Justice building, Cinna joins Haymitch to watch on a Sound Man's monitor.

EXT. TOWN SQUARE, DISTRICT 11 - CONTINUOUS

Slow-motion footage of Thresh and Rue is projected on huge screens around the Square. Katniss takes it in, keeping up her front. Then she stops, almost falters.

POV -- Rue's family -- her Mother and Sisters -- sit in a specially-roped area, draped with banners of Rue's face. Thresh's Grandmother and other family sit in an adjacent roped-off area, with banners showing Thresh's face.

Katniss forces herself to smile. Peeta steps to the mic.

PEETA
Thank you. We're honored to be with you today, and with the families of your fallen tributes.

She sees him quietly put aside the cards Effie gave him.

PEETA (CONT'D)
And though they fought and lived honorably and with dignity to the very end, Thresh and Rue were so young...

The crowd begins nodding. Katniss sees Rue's family consoling each other.

PEETA (CONT'D)
But our lives aren't just measured in years, but in the way we touch the lives of those around us. For me, and for Katniss, we both knew that without Rue and Thresh, we wouldn't be standing here today.

A MURMUR from the crowd -- moved by his generous words. Katniss watches, impressed. Peeta presses on, quickly.

PEETA (CONT'D)
In recognition of that, and knowing that it can in no way make up for your loss, we would like to donate one month of our winnings to the families of the two fallen Tributes every year, for the rest of our lives. Thank you.

He turns, leaves the podium. Surprise flickers through the crowd. Then they APPLAUD, heartfelt and grateful.

INT. JUSTICE BUILDIN, BACK-STAGE - DAY

Haymitch, worried, and Cinna, amused, watch the monitor.

HAYMITCH
Oh. Shit.

CINNA
Can he actually do that?

HAYMITCH
(staring at the monitor)
It doesn't matter.

EXT. JUSTICE BUILDING. DISCTRICT ELEVEN. DAY

Peeta offers the microphone to Katniss who shakes her head. There doesn't seem to be anything more to add. Then, she sees Rue's SISTER, in the first row, staring at her with both hope and reproach. She is not applauding. The Mayor begins to escort Katniss and Peeta off stage. Instead, Katniss pulls away and steps to the microphone.

KATNISS
I... I just wanted to say: I didn't know Thresh. I only spoke to him one time, just long enough for him to spare my life.
(MORE)

KATNISS (CONT'D)
He could have killed me, but instead, showed me mercy. That's a debt I can never repay.

Thresh's Grandmother looks up and smiles. Katniss turns.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I did know Rue.

She addresses Rue's Sister directly. Rue's smiling face fills the big screens around the square.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
She was not just my ally. She was...
(a look at Peeta)
She was my friend, and she will be with me the rest of my days. I see her in the flowers that grow in the meadow by my house. I hear her in the Mockingjay's song. I see her in my sister, Prim. She was so young, so gentle...
(tearing up)
I'm sorry...

And Katniss stops unable to continue. Silence. Then, in the crowd, and OLD MAN whistles the four-note Mockingjay tune that Rue used in the Arena.

And as one, everybody in the crowd presses the three middle fingers of their left hand to their lips and extends them towards her. The District Twelve salute.

Abruptly, a phalanx of Peacekeepers wades into the crowd. It quickly turns chaotic. Everyone tries to flee. Some are beaten. Children CRY. The crowd SCREAMS with fear. Katniss, on stage, is horrified to see Peacekeepers grab the Old Man who whistled and drag him forward.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Stop...! Please! Leave him alone!

A wall of Peacekeepers storm the stage, sealing it from the crowd. Katniss and Peeta are hustled back-stage.

Katniss turns back, trying to see what is going on. She sees the Old Man dragged up the steps onto the stage she just occupied. Just as she is pulled through the French doors, a Peacekeeper puts a pistol to the Old Man's head. Katniss screams. The doors SLAM shut just as a SHOT rings out.

INT. JUSTICE BUILDING, ROOMS - DAY

It's chaos. Haymitch approaches Katniss, who looks up at him, shaking.

KATNISS
What did I say? I was just trying to thank their families.

Haymitch immediately pulls Katniss and Peeta's microphones off their clothes.

HAYMITCH
Stop talking. Follow me.

He leads them off. They follow as he stalks through one empty room after another. He tosses their microphones aside. Up a back staircase, through more dusty rooms. Finally, he shoves open a door that looks as if it hasn't been opened in years to reveal a ladder and trap door.

INT. JUSTICE BUILDING, ATTIC - DAY

They come through a door into a room filled with broken furniture, old books, neglected weapons and a thick layer of dust. Haymitch shuts the door. Katniss is in shock, listens to the chaos outside.

KATNISS
The last thing I wanted was to start a riot.
(looks at them)
He has to know that.

HAYMITCH
What are you talking about? Who has to know that?

KATNISS
Snow. He came to see me.

HAYMITCH
Keep going.

KATNISS
He's worried about the Districts. He said they don't believe we're in love. They think I defied the Capitol and got away with it.

HAYMITCH
So he wants you to make them believe it.

KATNISS
To calm things down.

PEETA
And I just made things worse...

He looks at her, angry now...

PEETA (CONT'D)
You know, it would've been good to know all of that before I opened my mouth and offered to give them the money--

KATNISS
I'm sorry. I didn't know what to do -- He threatened my family.

He turns, swipes a lamp off a table, sending it crashing.

PEETA
I have a family too, all right? People I need to protect!

HAYMITCH
What about them? Who protects them?

He points at the window, toward the square.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
What were you thinking?

KATNISS
I was thinking about Rue.

And that takes some of the air out of everyone's anger. Haymitch stares out the window.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Haymitch. Please. Just help me get through this trip.

He looks at her.

HAYMITCH
This trip? Girl, wake up, this *trip* doesn't end when you get back home. This trip is going to last a lifetime. You don't ever get off this train.

He comes away from the window.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
You two are mentors now. That means every year they're going to drag you out and broadcast the details of your romance. Every year, your private life becomes theirs. Your story's already been written. Just not by you.

They look back at Haymitch, can feel his pain in this speech as much as the message he's trying to convey.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
From now on, your job is to be a distraction so people forget what the real problems are.

The gravity of this hits them both. They share a glance.

PEETA
So what are we going to do?

Haymitch looks at them -- resigned, affectionate.

HAYMITCH
You're going to smile. You're going to read the cards Effie gives you. And you're going to live happily ever after.

Peeta looks at Katniss. She turns to the window, watches as the Old Man's body is carried into an armored vehicle.

EXT. TRAIN TO DISTRICT EIGHT - SUNRISE

The train races through a lush, agricultural landscape.

PEETA (V.O.)
Katniss and I want to share with you our victory...

EXT. DISTRICT EIGHT SQUARE - TEXTILE DISTRICT - DAY

Another District speech. Peeta reads from Effie's overwrought cue cards while Katniss gazes at him "adoringly." The crowd is muted.

PEETA
...And our gratitude to the Capitol for bringing us together!

QUICK CUTS -- Peeta finishes speaking. The crowd claps. Katniss goes to him. They kiss, hug, and wave. Katniss sees people gazing up at her with hardened eyes.

PEETA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It was the bond of love, forged in the crucible of the Games, that was our greatest prize. For it is love, true love, that allows us all to bear our hardships...

INT. TRAIN, KATNISS'S CAR - NIGHT

Katniss, alone in bed -- sleepless and lonely and sad.

PEETA (V.O.)
...That mends the heart and banishes loneliness, and gives our lives meaning.

EXT. DISTRICT SIX SQUARE - TRANSPORTATION DISTRICT - DAY

Another speech, this time Katniss reads the cue cards.

KATNISS
We also want to share with you the sorrows of your losses. The Tributes of this district...

A teen COUPLE in the crowd gives her the D-12 salute. Katniss seeing it, falters. Peacekeepers wade in, grab the young couple, begin to haul them off. Katniss doesn't know what to do. She sees Haymitch watching. He nods at her cue cards -- go on. She swallows, continues.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
The Tributes of this district were great and noble warriors.

EXT. TRAIN TO DISTRICT FOUR- FISHING DISTRICT - DUSK

The train glides along a coastal landscape of steep hills and sandy beaches, crossing over arched bridges.

KATNISS (V.O.)
They brought honor to their families and pride to their people.

EXT. DISTRICT FOUR SQUARE - DAY

A crowd applauds as Katniss and Peeta step on the stage, smiling and waving. A pair of FLOWER GIRLS (8) hand them bouquets. As Peeta steps to the microphone, Katniss's Flower Girl looks up to her with star-struck eyes...

FLOWER GIRL
One day, I'm going to volunteer, like you did!

Katniss smiles kindly, but she dies a little inside.

INT./EXT. DISTRICT FOUR MOTORCADE - DAY

Through her window, she sees protesters sit on the ground handcuffed. Peacekeepers put bags over their heads. Not looking, she reaches for Peeta's hand, squeezes it.

INT. TRAIN, KATNISS'S CAR - NIGHT

Katniss startles, waking from a nightmare, CRYING OUT. She recovers. Peeta comes through the adjoining door, concerned. She holds her hand up -- I'm okay.

KATNISS
Just a dream.

PEETA
Probably a lot like the ones I have.
(then)
Every night.

They both sit there a moment, then--

PEETA (CONT'D)
Well...

He turns to go.

KATNISS
Peeta.

She reaches out.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Stay with me.

He looks at her. Comes back, sits next to her. Hushed:

PEETA
Always.

KATNISS (V.O.)
We are all of us united...

INT./EXT. MOTORCADE, DISTRICT THREE - DAY

The motorcade approaches a large, looming power plant.

KATNISS (V.O.)
...Both victors and vanquished...

Then, out the window, she sees another graffito, spray-painted on a wall, "The Odds Are NEVER In Our Favor".

KATNISS (V.O.) (CONT'D)
...In serving a common purpose...

INT. DISTRICT THREE POWER PLANT - DAY

Katniss finishes speaking to a surly, wound-up crowd, cordoned off from the stage by a line of Peacekeepers.

KATNISS
The power and glory of the Capitol.

From the crowd comes murmurs and angry cries.

CROWD
Put down those cards! Tell us what you really think! *Speak* to us!

Katniss is shaken. She presses on, finishing up.

KATNISS
Panem today. Panem tomorrow. Panem forever.

The CROWD surges forward, CALLING out, imploring her to speak honestly. Katniss feels gut-punched. Peacekeepers storm into the crowd. Batons come out. Katniss and Peeta are hustled off as the crowd YELLS at them.

INT. PRESIDENT SNOW'S QUARTERS, BREAKFAST ROOM - MORNING

VIDEO of Katniss and Peeta being hustled off stage.

Snow sits in a robe and slippers, eating breakfast by a pair of open French doors. It's sunny and tranquil. On the lawn, his GRANDDAUGHTER (11) can be glimpsed playing.

Snow watches as Katniss and Peeta are hustled off stage. The video is labelled "Classified: Security 1 Clearance".

He freezes the video, turns. Sees something frowns. On the lawn, his granddaughter's hair is in a single braid.

SNOW
Your hair looks very pretty, darling. When did you start wearing it like that?

GRANDDAUGHTER
Grandpa -- everyone at school wears it like this now!

Snow smiles at her, nods. He turns back to the video still of Katniss. Now he's a little more troubled.

HAYMITCH (V.O.)
Snow is watching us...

INT. TRAIN, OBSERVATION CAR - DAY

Quiet. Katniss, Peeta and Haymitch sit in the empty car, heads bowed. They know what they're doing isn't working.

HAYMITCH
...If he wants you to pacify the Districts, I promise you -- he's not happy. Instead of being in love, you two sound like you're reciting from a drilling manual.

PEETA
If only we could. <u>You</u> try and read that stuff Effie writes.

HAYMITCH
Tell that to President Snow when you see him...
(in Peeta's face)
...<u>two days from now</u>.

PEETA
I'm open to suggestions.

KATNISS
We could get married.

Peeta looks at her. Haymitch waves her off.

HAYMITCH
You're not helping.

KATNISS
I'm serious.

Okay. Now Haymitch looks at her.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I mean, if like you said, we're on this train forever. It's going to happen eventually. Why not now?

HAYMITCH
(thinks about it)
It's a statement, I'll give you that.

KATNISS
It makes it real.
(adds)
For the people.

HAYMITCH
There's an engagement, a wedding, all of that rigmarole to distract people from the real problems.
(then)
Also protects both your families.

They turn to Peeta. He nods, says without emotion:

PEETA
Sure. Why not.
(gets up)
Let's do it.

And like that, he walks out of the car. Katniss watches him go...

KATNISS
I thought that's what he wanted.

HAYMITCH
Not like this.

EXT. TRAIN - SUNSET

The train WHOOSHES past BELOW us, and we TILT UP to see the Capitol in the distance, framed by a setting sun.

CAESAR (V.O.)
And just when we thought the excitement couldn't get higher...

INT. STUDIO/TV SHOW

Caesar recaps an interview. Footage shows Peeta kneeling and asking Katniss to marry him. In the footage, Caesar reacts comically.

CAESAR (V.O.)
...The two lethal lovebirds from District Twelve surprised us all with a new twist in their story.

INT. MINER'S CHANGING ROOMS - NIGHT

A few miners watch TV in the break room. Gale, at his locker, stops, turns to watch. Can't hide his dismay.

CAESAR (V.O.)
A fairy-tale ending to a star-crossed romance.

EXT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, ENTRANCE - NIGHT

Effie leads Katniss and Peeta through the massive fat of Snow's Mansion, an oasis in the heart of the city. They are formally dressed. Ceremonial GUARDS line the drive.

CAESAR (V.O.)
And so tonight, a tour that began in the hollows of District 12 ends at the Presidential Estate.

Katniss stops -- she's never seen such opulence.

PEETA
Cozy.

EXT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, TERRACE - MOMENTS LATER

They ascend a set of double stairs leading to a terrace. There are fountains, gardens, flowers, butterflies. 3D projections of blooming white roses. Katniss gazes in wonder as Effie chatters and pulls them forward.

EFFIE
Come, come! This is your night! Absolutely everyone's here! They're all dying to meet you!

INT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, RECEPTION HALL - NIGHT

Decadence personified -- outrageous costumes and make-up; champagne flowing. As they step into the main hall there is a MURMUR of excitement. GUESTS turn, whisper while staring.

Effie waves, smiles and blows kisses at familiar faces. She speaks under her breath.

EFFIE
They're all here, aren't they? Absolutely everyone.

Even she's taken aback by the showing. She looks back at Katniss and Peeta, the two of them trying to maintain a sense of dignity... something that even Effie recognizes is a challenge. Katniss looks at her, as she's doing her own "smiling" and "waving."

KATNISS
How are we doing?

EFFIE
(quiet)
Don't worry about it.
(lays a gentle hand on Katniss' arm)
You're doing fine.

Katniss can hear the change in Effie's voice, looks at her, but Effie's off, back into her own character...

EFFIE (CONT'D)
Hello! Hello! Look at you and your lovely self! So good to see you!

EXT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, BACK GARDEN - NIGHT

They exit into the back garden, set up with lanterns, a dance floor, more WAITERS and GUESTS. Tables are piled high with elaborate food. Katniss and Peeta gawk, their minds reeling. Katniss has never seen such excess.

EXT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, BACK GARDEN - LATER

The party is in high gear. Elegant music plays. Guests chat and LAUGH. Katniss tries to stay "up" but her smile is fading. Peeta is eating one bite after another of hors d'oeuvres. Octavia hands him a plate of delicacies.

OCTAVIA
Try one of these. They're divine.

PEETA
I can't eat another thing.

FLAVIUS
Here.

He hands over a tiny stemmed wine glass filled with clear liquid. Over the following, Katniss turns, sees Haymitch chatting with Plutarch Heavensbee. They glance over, see her, smile. She turns away.

PEETA
What is this?

FLAVIUS
It's for when you're full.
(off his look)
Seriously.

OCTAVIA
It makes you sick. So you can go on eating.

FLAVIUS
How else could you taste everything?

Peeta gently puts the tiny wine glass down.

PEETA
...Time for a dance. Katniss?

He takes Katniss's hand and pulls her away.

EXT. PRESIDENTIAL MANSION, TERRACE - NIGHT

Peeta and Katniss join the dancing. An orchestra plays. The Presidential Mansion looms behind them.

PEETA
They're starving in Twelve. And here, they're throwing it up just to stuff more in.

EFFIE (O.C.)
Katniss...? Peeta...?

They turn. Effie is there with Plutarch.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
I'd like you to meet Plutarch Heavensbee. Head Game Maker. Successor to Seneca Crane.

He bows first to Peeta.

PEETA
That must be a hard act to follow.

Katniss elbows him. But Plutarch loves it.

PLUTARCH
Leave him be, my dear, I take no offense.
(to Peeta)
May I?

PEETA
Of course.

Peeta gives way to Plutarch who dances with Katniss.

PLUTARCH
So. How do you like the party?

KATNISS
It's a little overwhelming.

PLUTARCH
A little? Please. It's appalling. Still, if you abandon your moral judgment, it can be fun.

She stares. She's never heard anyone talk that way.

KATNISS
So are you having fun?

PLUTARCH
I'm Head Gamemaker. Fun is my job.

KATNISS
Is that what happened to Seneca Crane? Too much fun?

PLUTARCH
Seneca decided to give up breathing.

KATNISS
Decided?

PLUTARCH
It was that or poison berries.

He smiles. Katniss blanches. He enjoys her discomfort.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Don't feel so bad. Head Gamemaker has never been the most secure job in the world.

KATNISS
Then why are you here?

PLUTARCH
Same reason you are. I volunteered.

That stops her.

KATNISS
Why?

PLUTARCH
Ambition. The chance to make the games really mean something.

KATNISS
I thought they were meant to scare us.

PLUTARCH
To me, the games are art. A chance to create something beautiful.

KATNISS
People killing each other.

PLUTARCH
Have you looked at much art?
(then)
Then again, maybe it was <u>you</u> who inspired me to come back.

He looks at her. Is he serious?

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Tell me, is there anything you'd like to do while you're here in the Capitol?

KATNISS
No. Thank you.

PLUTARCH
You find no amusement in our hedonistic little hell hole?

KATNISS
There's nothing <u>I</u> want here.

He stops dancing, smiles at her with a strange sadness.

PLUTARCH
Careful, my dear. Authenticity is as rare here as it is dangerous.

Abruptly, the MUSIC stops. LIGHTS dim. A HORN sounds. The Anthem begins. Plutarch turns. On the mansion's wall, footage of white roses blooming is projected.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Ah! The Presidential welcome!

He takes out a pocket watch. Opens it. Smiles.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Like all good things...

A Mockingjay image flickers on the watch face. Katniss is unsure she saw anything.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
...it starts at Midnight.

He snaps is shut...

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
I'm sure we'll meet again.

He bows with a smile and departs, leaving her unsure of what just happened. Peeta rejoins her.

PEETA
What did he want?

KATNISS
(watching him)
I'm not sure.

She nods. Effie bustles in, grabbing them both.

EFFIE
Come -- you're the guests of honor!

Effies hustles them to a lit spot on the dance floor.

Everyone CLAPS as Snow steps on the balcony, graciously acknowledging the cheers. Katniss smiles and claps. Snow sees Effie in the crowd, and nods to her. Effie waves back giddily -- thrilled.

As the Anthem ends, Snow's eyes find Katniss -- hopeful, vulnerable.

SNOW
Tonight, on the last day of their Tour, I'd like to personally welcome the two Victors, two young people who embody our ideals of strength and valor -- and to offer them my congratulations on the announcement of their engagement.

Big CHEERS. Katniss and Peeta do an aw-shucks act -- smiling, blushing, waving. Snow gazes down at her.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Katniss, Peeta... Your love has inspired us. And I know it will go on inspiring us. Every day. For the rest of your lives.

He raises a glass to them. CHEERS. We see a quick glimpse of blood in Snow's champagne glass. Suddenly, FIREWORKS explode overhead. Everyone turns and looks upward.

On Katniss. She turns back, looks up at Snow. His eyes are upon her. Imperceptibly, he shakes his head 'no' at her. Her face falls. She understands she can never escape.

SOUND FADES. In this huge lavish assemblage of smiling, cheering, prosperous people, she feels utterly alone.

INT. TRAIN, KATNISS'S CAR - NIGHT

Katniss is wide awake. She lies back to back with Peeta who sleeps soundly to the RAIN that flashes by. She quietly gets up...

INT. TRAIN, CORRIDOR / SECURITY CAR - NIGHT

Katniss pads down the hall. Ahead, NOISE from an open door. She frowns, approaches. She peeks in.

Inside is the train's security room. Peacekeepers are gathered around monitors showing live footage from security cams in all 12 Districts -- most are placid.

EXT. DISTRICTS (MONITORS) - NIGHT

Monitors from a few Districts, however, show riots; tear gas; Molotov cocktails; fire hoses; angry mobs; etc.

On one screen, a wall of Peacekeepers, silhouetted by fire, marches toward a long young WOMAN who holds a sign over her head. A single image -- the Mockingjay logo.

INT. TRAIN, CORRIDOR / SECURITY CAR - NIGHT

Katniss stares, electrified. The revolution has begun. She starts backing away...

SNOW (V.O.)
She's not what they think.

INT. PRESIDENT SNOW'S DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Late. After the party. Snow watches the same footage. Plutarch steps into the doorway behind him. Without turning around.

SNOW (V.O.)
She's not a *leader*. She just wants to save her own skin. Simple as that.

Plutarch slumps into a chair across from Snow.

PLUTARCH
And since when is reality more important than perception?

Snow doesn't answer, just stares at the monitor.

SNOW
A slow poison.

PLUTARCH
Sir?

Snow turns to him now.

SNOW
We'll call it some kind of cancer. The Capitol will take heroic steps to save her. But despite our best efforts, Katniss Everdeen succumbs. A tragedy. Her weeping husband by her side.

PLUTARCH
Who would buy it. Not you, if you were watching.
(then)
(MORE)

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
I agree she should die, but in the right way... at the right time.

SNOW
She knew what I wanted of her. And I made it very clear to her what the consequences would be if she failed to comply. This Presidency does not make empty threats.

PLUTARCH
Sir, I don't care for politics. Affairs of State bore me to tears.
(then)
Moves and countermoves. That's what I live for. The angles. The way in and the way out. The Game. Winning the game. If I know anything, I know how to win.

Snow sits there. He's listening.

Plutarch watches as the young WOMAN holds up her Mockingjay sign.

SNOW
So what do you propose?

PLUTARCH
Start by sowing a little fear.

SNOW
But we're cracking down on the district even as you speak.

PLUTARCH
Crack down harder. Shut down the black markets. Take away what little they have. Then double the number of floggings and executions. Put them on TV. Broadcast them live. Sow a little fear.

SNOW
It doesn't matter how afraid they are as long as she is still giving them hope.

PLUTARCH
Katniss Everdeen is a symbol. They think she's one of them. We need to show she's one of us. We don't have to destroy her, just her image. And then the people will do the rest.
(MORE)

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
She's engaged. Make everything about <u>that</u>. What dress is she going to wear? What's the cake going to look like? Who's going to be there? Blanket coverage. Shove it in their faces. Show 'em she's one of <u>us</u> now. Let them rally behind that.

Snow takes that in. Plutarch smiles.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Make them hate her enough, they might just kill her for you.

Snow turns, stares at the frozen IMAGE of the young Woman holding the Mockingjay sing,

SNOW
Interesting that you volunteered for this position.

PRIM (V.O.)
Katniss...!

EXT. TRAIN PLATFORM - DAY

As Katniss steps off the train, Prim runs up to greet her. Her Mother walks up the platform, smiling. Prim jumps up and hugs Katniss. Katniss hugs and whispers.

KATNISS
Pack whatever you can. We're leaving.

Prim pulls back, stares. Katniss nods, determined.

EXT. DIRT ROAD - DAY - LONG SHOT

FAR DOWN THE ROAD. Coming around the corner is a shift of soot-covered MINERS -- silent, weary, broken. Gale is one of them.

PULLING BACK A BIT TO REVEAL KATNISS

Watching Gale from this distance. He listens absently as one of the miners tells a story. She sees how worn he is. But still finds herself watching him. Still feels glad to see him.

The other miners laugh out loud. Gale smiles, looks this way, and stops walking.

The other miners see her and grow quiet, nodding politely to her as they pass. Gale now at the rear... Katniss moving to meet him.

They face each other a moment. He's angry.

GALE
When did you--

She hugs him close. Takes him by surprise. Then she says into his chest, so no one can see or hear...

KATNISS
We need to talk.

EXT. FENCE - DAY

Gale is tense, wary. Katniss is quiet and direct.

GALE
Run away? Where?

KATNISS
Into the woods. Make a break for it. Like we talked about.

He's not sure.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
If we go right now we can all be far away from here by tonight?

GALE
Who's we? You, me and your fiancee?

KATNISS
Gale--

GALE
--*It's all an act.* I know. I know. You're just doing it to save you and Peeta.

KATNISS
Not just me and Peeta.
(then)
President Snow threatened to have <u>you</u> killed.

He looks at her, nods like she just told him what time it is.

GALE
Anyone else?

KATNISS
Well, he didn't actually give me a copy of the list. But it's a good guess it includes both our families.

GALE
Unless what? You and Peeta get married?

KATNISS
Unless nothing, now.

He looks back at her, takes in the meaning of that.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Gale, we can do this. You said yourself you thought we could do it, the morning of the reaping.
(then)
What do you say now?

He stares back at her.

GALE
I think it's the dumbest idea I've ever heard.
(smiles)
But I'll do it.

KATNISS
You will?

GALE
Yeah. Let's go and never come back!

She throws her arms around him, laughing as he picks her up and swings her around. He puts her down and holds her, touching foreheads. A moment, then--

GALE (CONT'D)
I love you.

KATNISS
I know.

Ouch. She realizes how horrible that sounds. He starts to pull away, she grabs hold of him-- tries to fix it--

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I know! And you know what you are to me!

Unconvinced, he pulls away.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I'm sorry-- I can't think about anyone that way right now. All I can think about every day, every waking minute since the reaping, is how afraid I am. There's no room for anything else.
(moves to him)
But if we could get away from here, somewhere safe, maybe I could be different.

GALE
You ever think maybe the president's bluffing?

KATNISS
He's not bluffing.

GALE
You announced your wedding. He's planning it. I don't think he can afford to kill you.

KATNISS
I don't think he's putting much thought into my wedding right now. Not with uprisings in District 8.

She immediately regrets saying this. He is taken aback,

GALE
What's going on in District 8?

She says nothing. He steps forward.

GALE (CONT'D)
What did you see?

KATNISS
I don't know. Probably nothing.

He waits. Knows there's more. She looks at him.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
People were in the streets. There were fires and the Peacekeepers were gunning people down, but the people were...

GALE
The people were what?

KATNISS
(looks at him)
They were fighting back.

He is electrified by the news. Looks back at the town.

GALE
So it's happening. Finally.

KATNISS
If I'd just eaten those berries, none of this would've happened. Peeta could've come home and lived his life. Everyone would be safe.

He turns, incredulous, angry.

GALE
Safe for what?! To starve? Work like slaves? Send their kids to the Reaping?
(looks around, then)
You haven't hurt people-- you've given them an opportunity. They just have to be brave enough to take it. There's already talk in the mines. People want to fight.

KATNISS
You're not listening-- we have to leave <u>now</u> before they kill us...! All of us.

GALE
And what about the other families? The ones who stay? What happens to them?

She says nothing to that. He knows she has nothing to say. He keeps his voice.

GALE (CONT'D)
People are looking to you, Katniss. You could do so much--

KATNISS
--I don't want people looking to me! I can't help them!

They both turn as SOUNDS of heavy machinery rumble in the distance. They duck down and watch the trees as an armada of armored personnel carriers roll down the road to town. Once it passes, Gale turns to her.

GALE
You do what you want. I'm staying.

EXT. SQUARE - DAY

Armored trucks roll into the square, drop their armored doors with loud BOOMS. Helmeted Peacekeepers flood out with batons, gas masks, and riot shields, and assemble.

A tall, severe man in a Head Peacekeeper uniform, Thread, steps out, looking pissed and ready to crack down. Cray, the paunchy current Head Peacekeeper, steps forward.

CRAY
Commander Thread! Welcome to 12!

He offers a handshake. Thread ignores him. Peacekeepers swarm Cray, slap a hood over his head, drag him off. His Deputies are unnerved. Thread turns to a Lieutenant.

THREAD
Get to work.

The Lieutenant pulls out a pistol, fires a SHOT in the air. The assembled Peacekeepers snap into action.

EXT. FENCE - DAY

Katniss and Gale hear the GUNSHOT echo.

KATNISS
Mom...
(looks at Gale)
Prim...

They start to head back towards town.

EXT. DISTRICT TWELVE SHANTY TOWN - DAY - MONTAGE

QUICK CUTS as Peacekeepers invade and search homes.

-- Doors are kicked in.

-- Men, women, children, and the elderly are pulled from their homes, children SCREAMING and CRYING in terror.

-- They are made to kneel in the snow, arms behind heads.

-- Inside, houses are ransacked. Cupboards yanked open. Drawers pulled out onto the floor.

-- Around the town, contraband food, clothes, books, hunting gear are thrown out windows and doors.

-- The contraband is tossed into piles.

-- A Peacekeeper pours out bottles of moonshine onto a pile of contraband, sets it alight. It burns.

-- Hooded ARRESTED CITIZENS are loaded into trucks.

EXT. DISTRICT TWELVE SQUARE - DAY

-- Using hi-tech equipment, Peacekeepers install a whipping post in the center of the square.

EXT./INT. HOB - DAY

Peacekeepers swarm out of an armored personnel carrier and invade the Hob. Screaming and chaos as Peacekeepers drag stall-holders out from their stalls, beat them and arrest them. The stalls are axed to pieces. Old women and children are pushed around. Ripper tries to stop one of them, he strikes her in the eye with the butt of his weapon...

Peacekeepers with flame-throwers set to work turning the Hob into an inferno.

EXT. ROAD TO HOB - DAY

Katniss and Gale run along the road. They stop. The Hob is on fire. She is horrified. He seethes.

Stragglers are fleeing. Ripper is limping, blood on her face, hand over her eye. Gale and Katniss approach.

RIPPER
Who is that? I can't see.

KATNISS
It's Katniss. I'll take you home.

Gale looks at her, then runs on toward the Hob.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Gale...!

EXT. HOB - DAY

Now an inferno. Stall-holders are thrown into vans. Greasy Sae is scrabbling in the snow, trying to pick up her few possessions. Thread kicks her in the stomach.

GALE
Don't touch her!

THREAD
Or you'll do what?

He aims another kick at Greasy Sae. Gale sweeps his other leg away. Thread falls and Gale punches him in the face.

GALE
I'll do <u>that</u>.

He lunges at Thread, but now Peacekeepers are all over him, dragging him off Thread. Thread gets to his feet, fingers his bloody nose.

THREAD
In the square. I want an audience.

EXT. DISTRICT 12 BUILDING - DAY

Katniss sits Ripper on the edge of a building next to a hand pump. She wets a cloth and starts wiping Ripper's face when we hear A WHIPCRACK followed by a distant SCREAM.

She turns. Sees people running away from the square.

EXT. SQUARE - DAY

Snow is falling heavily. A whip CRACKS. A muffled YELL. A crowd is guarded by a line of Peacekeepers. Katniss pushes through the crowd. An old lady tries to stop her.

OLD LADY
Get out of here, girl. You'll make it worse.

Katniss looks around, FACES staring back at her--

SOMEONE ELSE
You want to get him killed?

Katniss shakes them off, pushes forward, breaks through the curtain of people to find...

Gale, tied to a post. Thread whips him. Gale's naked back already a bloody mess. As Thread raises the whip for another lash...

KATNISS
Stop!

But Thread's already mid-stroke, Katniss already putting herself between him and Gale. The snapping whip stings her cheek and she goes down to her knees.

Thread is surprised. But determined. He raises the whip again. Katniss touches her cheek, gains her feet, and once more steps between Thread and Gale.

THREAD
Move--

KATNISS
No! Enough!

And without hesitating he cracks the whip again, she turns and takes the lash across the back. She keeps turned the pain almost too much. A whisper:

GALE
Katniss.

She opens her eyes, sees Gale, head ducked, looking at her.

GALE (CONT'D)
It's alright.
(then)
Go on.

She looks back at him. He almost smiles at her. Encouraging her. But instead of going, she slowly turns around and once more faces Thread who raises the whip.

KATNISS
(quietly)
Enough.

THREAD
Want another?

He lifts his whip. She stands her ground.

KATNISS
Go ahead.

Thread considers her a moment, now drops his whip, takes out his gun. She stands defiant. He raises the gun--

VOICE
Whoa, whoa, whoa--

Haymitch steps in front of her and raises his arms in a "hold off" gesture.

HAYMITCH
WHOA!

THREAD
Get out of the way.

HAYMITCH
You don't want to shoot her!

THREAD
I'll shoot both of you, you don't move aside--

HAYMITCH
Commander, trust me, I'm trying to help you here.

Haymitch grabs Katniss, shoves her in front of Thread.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Recognize her? Look hard. Katniss Everdeen? That name ring a bell?

Thread's face clouds with doubt.

THREAD
She interfered with a Peacekeeper.

HAYMITCH
I never said she was smart.

Thread looks around at the crowd. Waiting to see how he handles this. Haymitch knows what he's thinking--

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
You gave her a couple good lashes.

THREAD
That's not enough. She's an agitator.

He raises his gun. Peeta steps in his way.

PEETA
How many people you want to shoot today?

Thread lifts his gun, points it at Peeta. Haymitch steps in front of it, gun against his chest. He speaks sotto.

HAYMITCH
You sure Snow wants three Victors dead? Bad enough you marked up her face right before the big wedding.
(then)
Let it go. We will too.

Beat. Haymitch doesn't blink. Thread's eyes dart around the silent, watching crowd. He holsters his gun.

THREAD
(to Haymitch)
Next time it's a firing squad. I don't care who's marrying who.
(loud, to everyone)
Clear the square! You're all under curfew! Anyone out after dark will be shot on sight!

Thread looks at Haymitch a moment, motions to Gale, then turns away.

THREAD (CONT'D)
Get him out of here.

The Square empties. Katniss looks gratefully at Peeta and Haymitch. Thread turns, and WE SEE a CAMERAMAN in steadi-cam gear who has been filming. Thread glares at him.

THREAD (CONT'D)
Turn that camera off!

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE. DAY.

A group of miners carry in Gale, lying on an old door. Prim sweeps everything off the kitchen table. Katniss's Mother lays a fresh cloth down -- calm, business-like.

MOTHER
Here.

They lay Gale on the table. She glances at Haymitch.

HAYMITCH
New Head Peacekeeper.

She nods. Prim examines the cut on Katniss's face.

PRIM
Missed her eye. Doesn't need stitches. We'll get snow on it.

She looks at Peeta, who nods and goes out. Her Mother is already cleaning Gale's wounds.

MOTHER
Make a snow coat.

PRIM
I'll grind the herbs.

Prim fetches down various jars, starts tipping them into a weighing-scale. A groan comes from the table. Gale.

MOTHER
He needs Morphling.

Prim watches as her mother moves up beside her, tries to prepare the syringe with the Morphling, her hand shakes. She pauses. Prim puts a hand on her mother's.

PRIM
There's not enough to waste.
(smiles)
I'll do it.

Prim takes the syringe and expertly prepares it. Moves to where Gale lies--

PRIM (CONT'D)
Hold him, please.

Haymitch and Katniss hold him down as Prim injects him in the neck, like she's done it a thousand times. Gale cries out, arches his back for a moment, then settles--

PRIM (CONT'D)
He won't feel so much pain now.

Katniss looks at her sister, sees what she's become, finally nods. She then sits beside Gale.

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE, STUDY - NIGHT

Katniss sits alone with Gale, touching his unconscious face -- forehead, cheeks, chin. On his back are two muslin cloths with snow in between. She leans, kisses him. He opens his eyes, smiles weakly.

GALE
Hey, Catnip.

KATNISS
Hey, Gale.

She strokes his hair.

GALE
Thought you'd be gone by now.

KATNISS
I'm not going anywhere. I'm going to stay right here, cause all kinds of trouble.

He looks at her. Intimate, loving. Smiles again.

GALE
Me too.

EXT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DAWN - ESTABLISHING SHOT

One window lit in an otherwise dark neighborhood. Birds CHIRP at the first light of dawn.

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE STUDY - DAWN

Morning light. Peeta enters. Steps toward the study and stops. Katniss sits with her back to him, alone with Gale, stroking his hair.

Peeta's heart sinks. She loves Gale. He steps into the room. Katniss turns.

PEETA
Go to bed. I'll look after him.

Katniss gets up, exhausted, as Peeta takes her place.

EXT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - DAWN

Katniss is scooping snow into a large bowl. She pours a green liquid into it, mixes it with her hand. Prim comes out of the house -- winter clothes on -- and approaches.

KATNISS
Hey.

Prim arrives, hunches down, watches Katniss mix the snow.

PRIM
How's your eye?

KATNISS
It isn't my eye that's bothering me.

Katniss looks at Prim, shakes her head. Lowers her voice.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
How long can we live like this? How long can anyone?

PRIM
It's not living.
(then)
But since the last games, something is different. I can see it.

KATNISS
What do you see?

PRIM
Hope.

Katniss reaches out, brushes Prim's hair back.

KATNISS
You understand, whatever I do, it comes back to you and mom. And I don't want you to get hurt.

Prim absorbs that a moment, then...

PRIM
You saved my life. That has to mean something. You gave me a chance.

KATNISS
Yes. To live.

PRIM
No. To <u>do</u> something.
(then)
If you face them, we will too.

KATNISS
You're just a kid.

PRIM
That's just how you see me. When you're gone, I take care of Mom. I take care of the sick when she can't.

Snow turns away, thinking. On the wall is an Audubon-like print of a Jabberjay bird. He gestures to it.

SNOW (CONT'D)
We created that Jabberjay as a weapon. An organic spy mutt. After the program was shut down an extermination order was issued but was carelessly executed. A few of them escaped; flew into the wild. Mated with Mockingbirds.

Snow turns back to the VIDEO of Katniss.

SNOW (CONT'D)
So now we have the Mockingjay -- a species that shouldn't exist, an offspring of our neglect that we can no longer control...

Snow stands up, faces Plutarch.

SNOW (CONT'D)
If you can't contain Katniss Everdeen, then I will have to have her destroyed before she too is transformed and flies beyond our control.

PLUTARCH
I understand that.

SNOW
And not just her. Her entire *species* will have to be eradicated.

PLUTARCH
Her *species*, sir?

SNOW
The other victors.

He hits a button. The video continues -- Haymitch joins Katniss in standing up to Thread. Then Peeta joins too.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Because of her, they all now pose a threat. Because of her, they all now believe they're invincible.

PLUTARCH
If I may, sir, that's what makes them victors.

Snow pivots to a bank of monitors showing security cams in all 12 Districts. Most are placid. A few, however, show protesters; tear gas; fire hoses; angry mobs; etc...

SNOW
Whatever game you think you're playing, Heavensbee, they are not playing it with you. And I assure you a *wedding* is not going to be enough to prevent war!

PLUTARCH
No, sir, I suppose it isn't. But you still can't simply eliminate her without consequence.

Plutarch walks and stares out the window. Hands folded behind his back.

SNOW
I have no other choice.

Plutarch, thoughtful.

PLUTARCH
There's a way we can still win. A way we can first ruin her image, and then kill her without blowback.

He smiles now. Snow watches skeptically.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
It's what we gamemakers like to call... a *wrinkle*.

INT. CAPITOL BUILDING, CORRIDOR - AFTERNOON

Plutarch walks down a cement corridor toward a heavily fortified door. Two Guards stand at attention.

PRESIDENT SNOW (V.O.)
Ladies and Gentlemen, Citizens of Panem. This is the seventy-fifth year of the Hunger Games.

The LASER scans his retina. The door slides open.

INT. CAPITOL BUILDING, GAMES CHAMBER - AFTERNOON

The door shuts. The room is like a vault: spare, brutal. Plutarch walks to a wall safe, puts his hand on a sensor.

A green light. The door CLICKS. Inside is a small wooden box. He takes it out. He places the box on a table.

PRESIDENT SNOW (V.O.)
When the charter of the Games was written, it dictated that every twenty-five years there would be a Quarter Quell...

He blows dust from the lid. Unlocks it with a small key.

EXT. AVE OF THE TRIBUTES PRESIDENTIAL ENCLOSURE - AFTERNOON

President Snow addresses a camera, under lights, all the trappings of a state address (flags, guards) around him.

PRESIDENT SNOW
...To make fresh for each new generation the memory of those killed by the rebellion against the Capitol...

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - STUDY - AFTERNOON

Katniss, Prim and their Mother watch Snow on TV.

PRESIDENT SNOW (TV)
...The Quarter Quell was reserved for the Games of special significance.

INT. PEETA'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

Peeta stands watching Snow on TV -- intent, concerned.

PRESIDENT SNOW (TV)
On the 25th anniversary, each District was made to vote on the Tributes who would represent it.

INT. HAYMITCH'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

Haymitch casually pours himself a drinnk as Snow speaks.

PRESIDENT SNOW (TV)
On the 50th anniversary, as a reminder that two rebels died for every Capitol citizen, each District was required to send twice the Tributes to the arena.

INT. CAPITOL BUILDING, GAMES CHAMBER - AFTERNOON

Plutarch sits at the table, opens the boy. Inside is a single envelope, marked "3rd Quarter Quell".

PRESIDENT SNOW (V.O.)
And now, on the seventy-fifth anniversary of the rebellion, we honor our third Quarter Quell, as bestowed to us, by the signers of the Treaty of the Treason.

He takes the envelope out of the box.

Opens it to reveal a small ornate card with instructions on it. He holds it over a candle and burns it.

Plutarch dips a quill in ink and begins to write on a new card.

EXT. AVE OF THE TRIBUTES PRESIDENTIAL ENCLOSURE - AFTERNOON

The wood box is carried by a small boy, dressed in white, onto the stage. Snow opens the lid and extracts the yellowed envelope marked "3rd Quarter Quell". Makes a show of breaking the seal. Opens the envelope, reads.

PRESIDENT SNOW
"As a reminder that even the strongest cannot overcome the power of the Capitol, on this 3rd Quarter Quell Games, the male and female tributes are to be reaped..."

INT. KATNISS'S HOUSE - STUDY - AFTERNOON

Katniss and her family watch, tense but distanced. On TV, Snow frowns, feigning surprise, milking the moment.

PRESIDENT SNOW
Are to be reaped from the existing pool of victors in each District.

Silence. Katniss's Mother screams. Prim turns to Katniss who stares blankly at the screen.

PRIM
What does he mean, "existing pool?"

Katniss doesn't answer. Is in shock.

PRIM (CONT'D)
They can't make you go back again, can they?

She puts a hand on Prim.

KATNISS
It's alright.

She calmly gets up and walks out the door.

MOTHER
Katniss...

INT. HAYMITCH'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

Haymitch stares quietly at the set a moment, then explodes. Roaring, he hurls a bottles at the TV, shattering it as...

EXT. VICTOR'S VILLAGE, LAWNS - AFTERNOON

Katniss hurries away from the house. Her Mother appears in the door behind her.

MOTHER
Katniss!

Katniss veers into shadows, not wanting to be consoled.

EXT. TREES BY VICTOR'S VILLAGE - AFTERNOON

Katniss now runs. She makes her way deeper into the trees until she can't see anymore and stops, not knowing where to run to. An off-screen call:

MOTHER (O.S.)
Katniss...!!!

She drops to her knees then lies down in leaves, curling up in the fetal position. She balls up the front of her shirt, stuffs it in her mouth and SCREAMS.

EXT. TREES BY VICTOR'S VILLAGE - NIGHT

Katniss lies alone, silent. Face streaked with tears. Wrung out. Suddenly, she lifts her head. Whispers.

KATNISS
Peeta.

INT. HAYMITCH'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Katniss bursts in, tries to see in the dark...

HAYMITCH
There she is.

She sees him sitting alone at his kitchen table, bottle in hand, drunk. But not bitter or angry -- he's flying on an end-of-the-world kind of euphoria.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Finally did the math, huh?
(as she walks up)
And now you're here to what? Ask me to die...?

KATNISS
No.
(sits down)
I'm here to drink.

He laughs, shoves the bottle at her.

HAYMITCH
Finally. Something I can help you with.

She sits down, takes a few long slugs, ends up coughing.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
So what's it say that Peeta was here 45 minutes ago, begging to save your life. And you only turn up now.

Katniss absorbs this. Almost a whisper.

KATNISS
It means we have to save him.

HAYMITCH
You could live a hundred lifetimes and not deserve that boy.

She nods. Everything has backfired... all of her plans and good intentions have led to ruin. She clutches the bottle.

KATNISS
I don't care about myself. All I've done's make things worse for everyone.

HAYMITCH
You didn't make this happen.

KATNISS
Come on Haymitch, nobody decent ever wins the games.

He almost smiles. She doesn't mean it as an insult, just the truth. He leans over, puts his hand over hers--

HAYMITCH
You're wrong. Nobody *wins* the games period. There are survivors, but no winners.

They sit there a moment, these two survivors. She takes a drink, looks back at him.

KATNISS
Peeta has to survive.
(then)
Promise we'll save him.

He stares at her -- bruised, broken. He nods tenderly.

HAYMITCH
If they call his name, I'll volunteer in his place.

KATNISS
(relieved)
Haymitch. Thank y--

HAYMITCH
But--
(she tops)
If they call my name, and Peeta volunteers, there's nothing I can do.

KATNISS
You can help him in the arena. The way you helped me.

HAYMITCH
These games are going to be different.

KATNISS
I don't care. Whatever you can do to save him.
(then)
Peeta lives, not me.
(MORE)

KATNISS (CONT'D)
(holds out her hand)
Promise.

He finally nods, shake: deal. She slumps, relieved. Then she stands unsteadily, goes to the door, still holding the bottle. She turns.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
It'd be bad for you, wouldn't it?
Knowing all the other victors?

He reaches out, picks up a new bottle, cracks the seal...

HAYMITCH
Oh, I think we can count on it
being unbearable wherever I am.

...And Drinks. She turns and exits.

EXT. MEADOW - DAY

Springtime. The sun is shining. Wildflowers in bloom. Katniss and Gale sit in a meadow, heads bowed together. She finally brushes his hair from his face, kisses him. Then stands up, starts to walk away.

GALE
Katniss?

She pauses, looks back at him.

GALE (CONT'D)
We should have gone when you said.

She walks away, certain she will never see him again.

EXT. DISTRICT 12 STREETS - DAY

Citizens are shepherded by Peacekeepers into the Square. Katniss, Peeta, and Haymitch walk together, united. People make way. Gunslingers headed to a final showdown.

Katniss lets Peeta walk a bit ahead, catches Haymitch's eye. We've a deal, right? Haymitch nods -- don't worry.

EXT. SQUARE - DAY

A single slip of paper fluttering in a glass ball.

The Square is packed with sullen citizens. Peeta and Haymitch are one side of the stage, Katniss, the other.

Huge TVs have been mounted to show the proceedings. Effie, in a gold wig, stands at the reaping ball, trying to ignore the threatening edge to proceedings.

EFFIE
And the female Tribute from District Twelve is:

She tries to catch the single slip of paper in the ball. It eludes her. Nervous laughter from Effie. Finally she gets hold of it. Pulls it out and reads it flatly.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
Katniss Everdeen.

Not a flicker from the crowd. Effie looks to Katniss. Is that sadness on Effie's face? Then she brightens and turns to the crowd--

EFFIE (CONT'D)
Wonderful!

Effie moves to the other ball. Picks out one of the two pieces of paper fluttering inside. Katniss turns, looks at Peeta, locks eyes with Haymitch. He returns her gaze.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
And the male Tribute from District Twelve is:
(with relief)
Haymitch Abernathy.

But Haymitch closes his eyes. Katniss is devastated as--

PEETA
I volunteer.

He steps forward. The truculent crowd is silent. Effie glances at Haymitch, knows there's nothing she can do.

EFFIE
Very well! The male Tribute for the Third Quarter Quell is Peeta Mellark. So, it just remains for me-

But her words are lost as every citizen in the Square raises their arms in the three fingered salute. Haymitch, Peeta and Katniss raise their arms in reply. Prim is there in the crowd, this time stoic; proud.

A line of Peacekeepers deploy, separating them from the crowd. More Peacekeepers swoop in, march them off stage into the Justice Building.

The families of Katniss and Peeta surge forward, reaching out, calling their names. The Peacekeepers block them. Katniss tries to resist.

KATNISS
Wait! I need to say goodbye!

THREAD
New plan. Straight to the train.

PRIM
Katniss! Katniss!!!

Katniss turns. Prim pushes her way through the crowd. The Peacekeepers stop her. They make eye contact... Then Prim is gone.

INT. TRAIN, OBSERVATION CAR - DAY

Katniss hurries into the observation car, looks back at the receding town. In a few seconds, it's gone. She hangs her head. It's the last time she'll ever see it.

EXT. TRAIN - NIGHT

The train flashes through the darkness.

EFFIE (V.O.)
I've had a thought...!

INT. TRAIN, DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Empty, except for a somber table of Katniss, Peeta, Haymitch. Effie, in her gold wig, is trying to keep things up.

HAYMITCH
You don't say.

EFFIE
Katniss has her gold Mockingjay pin. I have my hair. I'm going to get you boys something gold.

They look at her, not sure what she means.

HAYMITCH
What for?

EFFIE
A token. Show them we're a team! That they can't...

Abruptly, she chokes up. Katniss is surprised and moved by this. Takes Effie's hand. Even Haymitch is humbled.

KATNISS
Thank you, Effie.

EXT. CAPITOL - MORNING

Aerial Shot - We soar down the Avenue of the Tributes toward the gleaming new Tribute Center.

EFFIE (V.O.)
It's *all* different with the Quarter Quell this year...

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, ATRIUM - DAY

An elevator carries them up through a hole, ascending through the atrium of the gleaming new Tributes Center.

EFFIE (V.O.)
New Tribute Quarters! New Training Center!

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, ELEVATOR - CONTINUOUS

Effie, Katniss, Peeta, and Haymitch ride the elevator, gazing in awe at the giant, Fascist-architecture atrium.

EFFIE
Isn't it fabulous?! They put *everything* into this building!

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Effie escorts Katniss and Peeta, with Haymitch in tow.

EFFIE
Beauty spa today! Chariots tomorrow! Training for two days. Then your Gamemakers session so they can rate your chances...

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

They enter their wildly voluptuous living quarters.

EFFIE
...And last but not least, the final television interview.
(re: living quarters)
Not bad, eh? Any questions?

Peeta raises his hand.

PEETA
Yeah.
(looks at Haymitch)
Who's trying to kill us?

EXT. DISTRICT ONE SQUARE - LUXURY GOODS DISTRICT - DAY

A TV SCREEN shows the Reaping in District One. Gloss and Cashmere, blond and beautiful, wave to a cheering crowd.

HAYMITCH (V.O.)
Cashmere and Gloss. District One. Brother/sister. Won back-to-back Games. Capitol favorites, lot of sponsors. They will be lethal.

EXT. DISTRICT TWO SQUARE - MASONRY/WEAPONS DISTRICT - DAY

WIDER -- Katniss and Peeta watch as Haymitch scrubs quickly to a video file to the District 2 Reaping.

Brutus is Huge, scary, eager to get back into the Arena. Enobaria smiles, revealing teeth sharpened into fangs.

HAYMITCH
District Two. Brutus and Enobaria.

KATNISS
What's with her teeth?

HAYMITCH
Had them filed into fangs so she could rip people's throats out.

PEETA
(staring at her)
She's committed, I'll give her that.

HAYMITCH
Also a lot of fun at parties.

HAYMITCH
One.

A young woman, ANNIE, goes into hysterics when her name is called, but she is quickly replaced when an 80-year-old woman with a cane, MAGS, volunteers, takes her place.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Mags volunteered for Annie. She was Finnick's mentor. Basically raised him. If he's trying to protect her in any way, it exposes him.

Haymitch watches as Finnick bends down to Mags, hugs her.

KATNISS
Guy like that, he has to know she doesn't stand a chance.
(watching him)
I bet it comes down to it, he doesn't protect her.

HAYMITCH
I just hope whenever she goes, she goes quickly.

INT. CHARIOT STAGING AREA - DAY

Katniss exits an elevator door and the Chariot Staging Area. She is already made up and wears a fitted black outfit.

She stops. This looks familiar: horses are being hitched to chariots. The Tributes and Mentors stand in small groups chatting. She looks for Peeta and Haymitch. They are not there. She turns her attention to a nearby horse, stroking his neck, and talking to him like a confederate.

KATNISS
Hey. Where'd we go wrong, huh?

FINNICK (O.C.)
Hello, Katniss...

She turns. Finnick steps up, disarmingly friendly, draped in a golden net with a strategically placed knot. He carries a few sugar cubes... pops one into his mouth.

KATNISS
Hello, Finnick.

FINNICK
Sugar cube?

He holds out his hand, his palm piled with cubes.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
They're supposed to be for the horses, but who cares about them? They've got years to eat sugar. Whereas you and I... well, if we see something sweet, we better grab it.

He smiles at her, *that* smile.

KATNISS
No thanks, but I'd love to borrow your outfit sometime, though.

FINNICK
Yeah, well, I've got to say, you're pretty terrifying in that get up. What happened to your pretty little-girl dresses?

KATNISS
I outgrew them.

Runs his fingers through the fur on her collar.

FINNICK
You certainly did. Shame about this Quell thing. You could have made out like a bandit in the Capitol. Jewels, money, anything you wanted.

KATNISS
I don't like jewels and I have more money than I need. What do you spend all yours on anyway, Finnick?

FINNICK
Oh, I haven't dealt with anything as common as money in years.

KATNISS
Then how do people pay you for the pleasure of your company?

He leans in close, whispers.

FINNICK
With secrets. What about you, Girl on Fire? Any secrets worth my time?

KATNISS
I'm an open book. Everybody seems to know about my secrets before I know them myself.

He looks off, sees Peeta, in a matching outfit, approaching with Cinna.

FINNICK
Unfortunately, I think that's true.
(then)
Sorry you had to cancel your wedding. I know how *devastating* that must be for you.

He tosses a cube in his mouth and saunters off. Unsettled, she turns, sees Peeta now walking up.

PEETA
Hey. What did he want?

KATNISS
To know all my secrets.

PEETA
Yeah, well. He's going to have to get in line.

Katniss and Peeta step up their chariot. Cinna places metal half crowns on their heads.

CINNA
Here. One last touch.

ANNOUCNER (V.O.)
Prep Teams to leave the floor. All Prep Teams to leave the floor.

Cinna zips up the neck zipper on her jumpsuit. Quietly.

CINNA
No waving and smiling this time. Look straight ahead. As if the audience and this whole event is beneath you.

KATNISS
Finally, something I'll be good at.

Cinna grins, presses a small remote control in her hand.

CINNA
When you're ready. Good luck.

Cinna leaves. Trumpets. Tributes mount their chariots which begin to glide forward. The crowd begins to ROAR...

INT. CHARIOT STAGING AREA - TUNNEL - CONTINUOUS

Katniss and Peeta's chariot approaches the looming LIGHTS and ROAR. She turns to him. Their eyes meet. Wordlessly, their hands find each other, squeeze. STAY on them as...

EXT. AVENUE OF THE TRIBUTES - CITY CIRCLE - CONTINUOUS

...Katniss and Peeta's chariot pulls out of the staging area tunnel and the horses gallop past the ROARING crowds. They stand together, united -- brave, stoic, aloof.

EXT. SKYBOX - DAY

Caesar and Claudius watch as Katniss and Peeta enter.

CAESAR
...And finally, from District Twelve, the couple everyone's talking about -- Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark!

CLAUDIUS
And I'll bet we see something special from their costumes, designed by super-stylist, Cinna.

EXT. AVENUE OF THE TRIBUTES - CITY CIRCLE - DAY

Katniss presses the remote in her hand. The outfits begin to pulsate with dark red light, ebbing and flowing like hot coals of a fire. The crowd ROARS their approval.

CAESAR (V.O.)
And right you were, Claudius! Like glowing embers from the Coal District! Unbelievable!

As each chariot gallops past the Presidential Enclosure, all the Tributes turn and wave to President Snow as they thunder past. Snow raises a hand to each in return. Katniss and Peeta's chariot passes Snow. Katniss looks straight ahead, not acknowledging Snow. Peeta sees this.

PEETA
Katniss...

KATNISS
What's he going to do, kill me?

Both Katniss and Peeta ignore Snow. Snow stops mid-wave. Katniss steals a glance. Their eyes meet. She gives him a defiant look. Snow lowers his hand. His face sours.

EXT. CHARIOT STAGING AREA/ELEVATOR - DAY

The tunnel is a chaos of dismounting Tributes and Stable Hands grappling with horses. Everyone is buzzed. As Peeta and Katniss's chariot stops, Haymitch is waiting.

HAYMITCH
Nice. Way to make friends out there.

KATNISS
I learned from the best.

Chaff and Seeder approach.

HAYMITCH
Katniss, meet Chaff and Seeder. Don't invite them over or they'll drink all your liquor.

Before Katniss can reply Chaff taker her head in his hands and kisses her on the lips. Katniss recoils. Haymitch and Chaff crack up.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Come on. Let's get that make-up off.

He leads them into a nearby elevator. As the doors close, a strikingly beautiful Tribute, Johanna Mason, slips in, wearing a lumber-themed costume.

INT. ELEVATOR - DAY

Johanna yanks off her leafy headdress, throws it away. As she talks she discards various accessories.

JOHANNA
You guys look amazing. My stylist is such an idiot. District Seven -- lumber, trees. I'd like to put my axe in his face.
(turns to them)
So what's it like knowing the whole world wants to sleep with you?

KATNISS
I really don't think...

JOHANNA
(cutting in)
I'm sorry, I was talking to him.
Can you unzip?!

She turns her back to Peeta. Peeta politely pulls the zipper down. Johanna -- freed -- shrugs out of her dress, letting it fall to the floor. They are startled. Ding! The doors open. Johanna, naked, turns and grins.

JOHANNA (CONT'D)
Thanks. Let's do this again some time.

She glances wickedly at Katniss, turns, walks off. They watch her go, agog. As the doors close, Katniss elbows an open-mouthed Peeta in the gut. Haymitch grins.

HAYMITCH
Johanna Mason. District 7. Sharp tongue, sharper ax. Hey--
(nudges Peeta)
Wake up.

Peeta slips out of his daydream. Haymitch points to him.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Don't be fooled.

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Katniss and Peeta enter the dining room. Haymitch, at the bar, is pouring himself a glass of wine.

Displayed on the glass table top are digital dossiers -- background folders on each rival Tribute, with their names and full-sized faces on each cover. They can be opened, re-sized, and moved around by finger swipes.

HAYMITCH
Ok, listen up: This isn't like last year. All of these Tributes know each other. You guys are the new kids.

PEETA
What does that mean?

He joins them at the table, taking a seat.

HAYMITCH
It means you've got to make friends.

KATNISS
I'd rather just be with Peeta.

HAYMITCH
That's not enough. They've seen you fight. They'll be coming after you. You're going to need at least a few others in your corner.

PEETA
You want us in the pack?

HAYMITCH
Not necessarily. Choose who you like. All of them are killers. Make it known you're willing to team up. You're targets, but you're good allies -- popular with the audience, and you can fight.

KATNISS
(looking around)
How can we trust any of those people?
(looks at Haymitch)
How can they trust <u>us</u>?

HAYMITCH
--It's not about trust, it's about staying alive.

INT. TRAINING CENTER - DAY

Katniss and Peeta enter the perimeter of the Center.

HAYMITCH (V.O.)
...So you need to find someone who's going to help you survive.

They look at the Tributes at various Stations. Unlike the first games, the atmosphere and attitude this time is different. Only a few Tributes are here, and those that are, only a few actually bother to train.

KATNISS
Where is everybody?

They look to where a Tribute from District 5 slumps in a chair, holding a liquor bottle. He leans over, vomits onto the mat. Katniss looks away.

PEETA
Not exactly the same level of enthusiasm as last time.

KATNISS
So far, I'm not overwhelmed by our choices.

PEETA
I guess just figure out who you trust least and work backwards from there.

Peeta departs, walking to the Spear Station, where Chaff and Brutus are training. Katniss watches. Brutus throws a spear, GRUNTING ferociously. It goes through A HUMAN-FORM HOLOGRAM, taking its head off as well as the arm of another HUMAN-FORM HOLOGRAM behind it. Peeta turns and looks at Katniss-- holy shit.

Johanna, at a fighting station, swings her battle axe ferociously. She sees Katniss watching and raises the axe over her head. It looks as if she is about to hurl it right at Katniss... But she sinks the axe into the mat and smiles.

JOHANNA
Want to play?

Katniss nods to the men watching her...

KATNISS
Looks like there's already a line.

Johanna shrugs, turns to Gloss and the Trainers.

JOHANNA
Boys? I'll be gentle.

Katniss goes to the knot station by herself, picks a rope. Finnick comes up behind her, slides his arm around her.

FINNICK
Here. Let me show you the best knot to know in the Arena.

He takes her rope and quickly ties a complicated knot. Holds it up: a noose. He slips it on, comically pretends to hang himself. Katniss rolls her eyes, moves on.

INT. SURVIVAL STATION - DAY

Peeta is being painted by a Morphling.

She is a thin, damaged individual, nervously giggling as she paints Peeta's face with muds and berries.

Katniss watches them. Suddenly, the second Morphling flickers into view, "appearing" out of the wall of the station. Katniss cracks a smile, and moves on...

...She walks past the Tributes from District 3, Wiress and Beetee, both mature and a little vague, who are trying and failing to light a tinder, striking flint to steel. Katniss stops to watch. Beetee sees her.

BEETEE
The flint takes particles off the steel, exposing the iron which reacts to oxygen in the air, creating the necessary spark...

He tries a few more times. Nothing.

KATNISS
You just have to hit it harder.

She steps forward, takes the flint, with a quick strike -- Poof -- she sets tinder alight. Wiress teases Beetee.

WIRESS
A little brute force...

BEETEE
...Is always helpful.
(to Katniss)
Thank you.

Then Wiress sees something over Beetee's shoulder. She nods to the balcony where the Game Designers watch. Plutarch stands watching all the Tributes. Katniss turns.

WIRESS
By the corner of the table...

KATNISS
Plutarch?

Beetee turns and peers from behind his glasses. Plutarch apparently looking at him. Beetee stares.

BEETEE
A force field.

Katniss turns and looks. She doesn't see anything.

KATNISS
How can you tell?

BEETEE
The shimmering. Top left hand side.
You see it?

She looks. In a small spot, the air is rippling slightly.

WIRESS
To separate us and them.

KATNISS
Probably my fault. I shot an arrow
at them last year.

They grin at this.

BEETEE
It's electromagnetic.

KATNISS
How can you tell?

BEETEE
How can I tell?

He looks at Wiress. Smiling.

Wiress cracks up at Beetee. Katniss looks from one to the other--

KATNISS
Is it obvious or something?

BEETEE
Is it obvious!

WIRESS
They might as well have a sign...

And now they're laughing again. Katniss grabs Beetee by the shoulder and turns him back to her. He gets serious:

BEETEE
Okay. Yes. See... the strength of
an electromagnetic field is
determined by the strength of the
electric current flowing through
it. The larger the current, the
larger the force of the
electromagnetic field...

KATNISS
And so--

BEETEE
Look around.
(she does)
All of the holograms, the lights, every now and then, they all flicker. Why?

KATNISS
Because the force field is taking up so much energy.

BEETEE
Dead giveaway. But...

He looks around.

BEETEE (CONT'D)
But there is a flaw:
(leans close)
Because we can see it, we know it is there.
(looks right at Katniss)
There's always a flaw in the system.

Katniss looks up at the Gallery where Plutarch stands, gazing down at her. He smiles down at her, walks away.

INT. CAMOUFLAGE STATION - MOMENTS LATER

Peeta is at a big sink, washing paint off his arms. She leans against the sink, looking out. He sees her.

PEETA
So. Make any *friends?*

KATNISS
I think they all may be just a little insane.

PEETA
I think you'd have to be.
(off her smile)
Keep looking.

INT. SWORD FIGHTING STATION / FOOD SURVIAL STATION - DAY

Katniss circles past the sword fighting station, where Enobaria is dueling an INSTRUCTOR.

She attacks fiercely, backing him up, then knocks the sword from his hand. Victorious, she puts her sword to his neck, bares her teeth, HISSES.

She turns to the knife section. Cashmere is staring at her with undisguised animosity. Next to her, gloss is throwing knives into holographic human targets with great relish.

Katniss, unimpressed, turns, sees Mags, from District 4, sitting alone at Food Survival, tying fish hooks onto fishing line. Mags sees her and smiles. Katniss approaches Mags, sits down next to her.

KATNISS
Hey... I saw you volunteer for that girl. That was very brave.

Mags, smiling, points at herself, shakes her head -- No. Points at Katniss, nods -- Yes. Katniss understands.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Prim's my sister.

Mags pats her hand. Katniss looks are her, charmed.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Listen, you teach me how to tie a fish hook, I'll teach you how to hunt. Deal?

Mags smiles at her -- appreciating the offer. Nods.

INT. ARCHERY STATION - LATER

Mags stands at a control panel. Katniss, a full quiver on her back, threads an arrow and draws her bow...

KATNISS
Set it to a "10". Ready.

Mags turns a dial, gets a nod from Katniss, hits a button. The WHINE of machinery getting into high gear. Abruptly, life-sized holographic human targets begin rushing at her, bearing weapons.

Pow, pow, pow, pow. Katniss hits them all.

More targets come from all directions -- jumping from balconies, popping out from behind obstacles. Faster and faster.

Pow, pow, pow, pow...! Katniss hits them all bullseye. It's impressive. The target range machinery WHINES down to a SILENCE. Katniss smiles, offers the bow to Mags.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Okay, now you try.

Mags nods -- look. Katniss turns. All the Tributes are watching her silently -- jaws dropped, intimidated.

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Katniss and Peeta are sitting down to dinner as Haymitch enters and joins them, grinning.

HAYMITCH
Good news. At least half the Tributes want you as an ally.

PEETA
They saw her shoot.

HAYMITCH
Well, sweetheart, you got the pick of the littler.

Katniss pushes forward the dossiers of Wiress and Beetee.

KATNISS
I like Wiress and Beetee.
(off Peeta's reaction; pointing to Haymitch)
What?! You said they're brilliant!

PEETA
Johanna calls them "Nuts and Volts."

HAYMITCH
Great. Anyone else?

KATNISS
(hesitates, embarrassed)
I like Mags.

Peeta rolls his eyes. Katniss sees this.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Okay, then no one!

HAYMITCH
I'll tell them you're still making up your mind.

INT. TRAINING CENTER, WAITING AREA - DAY

All of the Tributes are chatting and joking while they wait for their personal training sessions. Katniss and Peeta sit watching all the people they've gotten to know. Mags passes, pats Katniss on the head. Katniss smiles, watches her walk off. Turns back.

KATNISS
Peeta...
(he looks over)
...How are we going to kill these people?

He looks at her, then looks down. He has no answer.

INT. TRAINING CENTER, WAITING AREA - DAY

LATER -- Katniss sits alone, stewing. Angry at the world.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Katniss Everdeen.

Katniss looks up, and heads to the Training floor.

INT. TRAINING CENTER - DAY

She enters as Peeta is exiting. They make eye contact. He gives her a half-smile. She enters the room and stops.

In the center of the room is a still-wet painting of Rue lying in the bed of flowers Katniss laid for her. Katniss stares at the painting, glances back at Peeta just as he disappears from view. Back to the painting.

PLUTARCH
Miss Everdeen...? Miss Everdeen.

Katniss turns around. The Gamemakers look down on her with interest. Plutarch gazes down from on high.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
You have two minutes to present your chosen skill. You may begin.

Katniss looks up at him, an idea forming.

QUICK CUTS -- Katniss grabs paint. A rope. Goes to a dummy. Paints a beard. Whips a noose around its neck. Throws the rope over a beam. Pulls it up so it dangles. She turns and flings the last paint up at the Gamemakers. It SIZZLES as it hits the force field. She nods, polite.

KATNISS
Thank you.

She leaves. On the dummy she has written "Seneca Crane", The other Gamemakers are horrified... Except for Plutarch. He watches her walk out, smiling.

EXT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, ROOFTOP - SUNSET

The sun sets over a panoramic view of the Capitol. They sit together in a beautiful rooftop, tense and worried, not looking at each other.

PEETA
Okay, that was probably not the best idea we've ever had.

KATNISS
I'm glad I did it. You too.

PEETA
Snow's not going to be happy--

KATNISS
I don't care what Snow or--
(gestures)
--anyone in the Capitol thinks. I'm not going to be a piece in their game.

A quiet moment. She looks off at the sky...

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Hey. Look at that. Your favorite color. Orange. "Like a sunset."

He smiles at her, pleased she remembered.

PEETA
Like a sunset.

CAESAR (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen...

INT. CAPITOL AUDITORIUM - TV SHOW - NIGHT

Caesar stands before a vast Capitol studio audience.

CAESAR
...The final night has arrived...

INT. CAPITOL AUDITORIUM - TV SHOW - NIGHT -- JUMP CUTS

Beetee, academic, challenges the Quell's legitimacy.

BEETEE
If the Quell has been written by men, surely it can be unwritten.

Johanna is impassioned.

JOHANNA
The signers of the Treaty of Treason would never let this stand...

Seeder is quiet and dignified.

SEEDER
If President Snow is so powerful, why can't he change the Quell?

Chaff is angry, confrontational.

CHAFF
He could change it if he wanted. So he must not want to.

INT. DRESSING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Katniss watches the TV as the studio audience APPLAUDS Chaff's provocation. Cinna finishes touching her up.

CINNA
Okay, done.

Angle -- Katniss stands in a beautiful wedding dress.

KATNISS
Will I be twirling this year?

CINNA
Save it for the end.

They share a smile. Effie sticks her head in.

EFFIE
One minute. Is she ready?

Effie sees Katniss in her dress and reacts, emotional.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
Oh, my dear...! You would have been the most beautiful bride!

She chokes up. Katniss goes and hugs her. Effie wipes her tears.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
Come on. Let's show them what real beauty looks like.

INT. CAPITOL AUDITORIUM - TV SHOW - NIGHT

Effie leads Katniss to the stage wings. The Tributes sit side-by-side on stage as Caesar prattles on. Johanna is in the wings, dress being repaired by her Stylist.

JOHANNA
Really? A wedding dress? Just how much attention do you need?

KATNISS
Snow made me wear it.

Johanna's face shows pity, then empathy, then defiance.

JOHANNA
Make him pay for it.

A genuine smile between them. Caesar introduces her.

CAESAR
...Last year's victor from District Twelve, Katniss Everdeen...!

We FOLLOW Katniss as she walks out into the lights.

Big APPLAUSE. Katniss sees the other Tributes staring at her dress. Caesar kisses her cheek. She takes a seat.

CAESAR (CONT'D)
You look fabulous! Doesn't she?

Audience APPLAUSE. Caesar goes into solemn, ultra-unctuous mode. Leans in, fake-intimmate, fake-emotional.

CAESAR (CONT'D)
Now, Katniss. This is obviously an emotional night for all of us...

KATNISS
Don't start crying on me, Caesar.

Big LAUGH. Caesar plays along, laughing at himself.

CAESAR
I can't make any promises.

KATNISS
I wouldn't believe you anyway.

Huge LAUGH. Even Caesar loves it. As things settle down, he turns to the audience:

CAESAR
And we were so looking forward to your wedding. Weren't we, folks?

APPLAUSE and CRIES of sympathy. She nods graciously.

CAESAR (CONT'D)
Alas. And this is the dress you would have worn?

KATNISS
President Snow thought everyone would want to see it.

APPLAUSE. Yes! Yes!

CAESAR
Would you...?

He gestures to the floor. Katniss smiles to herself. Gets to her feet. Looks out, finds Cinna in the crowd. Eye contact. Does a twirl and then another. As she spins, the dress begins to smoke and then catch fire. Screams from the audience. Katniss is surprised. She glimpses Cinna nodding at her, encouraging her on.

Katniss keeps spinning as the dress burns high then gradually comes to a halt. She is surrounded by a circle of smoldering ashes. The white wedding dress has burnt away to reveal a black, fitted dress. APPLAUSE. Then Katniss lifts her dress arms, revealing... A bird outline in silhouette. Black. Sleek. Feathered. Jay-like streaks of white on the sleeve "wings".

CAESAR (CONT'D)
Oh, my! Feathers! Like a bird! Like...

KATNISS
A mockingjay.

A defiant smile. Big APPLAUSE from the audience.

INT. PRESIDENT SNOW'S QUARTERS, DEN - NIGHT

President Snow watches icily, fury mounting.

CAESAR
Your stylist has surpassed himself. What theatricality! Cinna, a bow.

On TV, the camera zooms in on Cinna who nods modestly.

CAESAR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
In a cruel twist of fate...

INT. CAPITOL AUDITORIUM - TV SHOW - MINUTES LATER

Peeta is the last interview. Wearing a tux, he shares his stoic anguish with a solemn, melodramatic Caesar.

CAESAR
...Your love with Katniss. Now cut tragically short.

PEETA
Caesar, we had a year together. A year I wouldn't trade for anything.

CAESAR
And the wedding... Never to be.

PEETA
No, we... We got married. In secret. We wanted our union to be eternal.

Caesar puts his hand on Peeta's, eyes filling with tears. Peeta shakes his head -- humble, noble, stoic, tragic...

PEETA (CONT'D)
I don't mind dying. Katniss and I have been luckier than most. I'd have no regrets at all if it weren't for...

He falters, overcome. HUSHED. Not a dry eye in the house. Everyone leans forward to hear -- even Katniss.

CAESAR
Weren't for what?

PEETA
If it weren't for the baby!

He bows his head. SCREAMS. Chaos in the audience. Katniss is shocked. Caesar is talking, but can't be heard over the HUBBUB of the crowd.

CAESAR
Ladies and gentlemen, the Tributes of the Third Quarter Quell...!

Peeta goes to Katniss, hugs her. The ANTHEM begins. She turns faces the crowd, holding Peeta's hand. In the crowd, Haymitch offers a "bravo" gesture to Peeta. Nicely played. Then Katniss takes Chaff's hand. Spontaneously, all Tributes grab hands in a show of solidarity.

The audience is stunned. Finnick raises his arms over his head. They all follow -- united, defiant, triumphant. The crowd goes CRAZY. Caesar is rendered speechless. There are CRIES and CALLS from a few in the audience.

CROWD
Cancel! Stop it! Cancel the Games! Call them off! Cancel!!!

Abruptly, the in-studio monitors cut to static, and the house LIGHTS go dark.

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Peeta is at the windows, looking down into the streets. Katniss sits apart, pensive, clutching a pillow.

PEETA
They're going crazy down there.

POV -- In the street a huge crowd is chanting, scuffling.

KATNISS
They won't cancel. They can't.

She turns to Peeta. He feels her looking at him.

PEETA
What?

KATNISS
We got married?

PEETA
Apparently.

KATNISS
And I'm pregnant?

PEETA
You look great--

KATNISS
--Peeta.

PEETA
Sorry. Once I got started, I couldn't stop.

KATNISS
Next time, maybe a little heads up?

PEETA
I can do that.

They share a smile when Haymitch enters, with Effie. Katniss and Peeta turn. He shakes his head.

HAYMITCH
Still on.

They absorb this, nod. A pause -- this is goodbye.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
Listen, it's a Quarter Quell year. There's usually a theme. Look for an underlying pattern.

They nod. Effie steps forward.

EFFIE
I have something for you boys.

She hands Peeta and Haymitch small clamshell jewel cases. Peeta and Haymitch, frown, open them. Peeta's contains a small gold medallion. Haymitch lifts out a gold bangle.

HAYMITCH
What's this?

EFFIE
Your token, remember? Hair for me. Pin for Katniss. Bangle for you. For Peeta: the medallion we talked about.

She smiles at Peeta who nods. She looks at all of them.

EFFIE (CONT'D)
We're a team, aren't we?

PEETA
Thank you, Effie.

She smiles, but her eyes grow misty. She goes and hugs Peeta, then Katniss.

EFFIE
I want you to know I'm proud of my Victors. That you both look so--

She stops. Enough cheerleading. She says what she feels:

EFFIE (CONT'D)
You both deserved much better.
(then)
I'm sorry.

She lifts a handkerchief to her face. Choking back a meltdown, she turns with great dignity and departs. Haymitch nods to them, and turns to follow her.

PEETA
Haymitch.
(he turns)
Thanks. For everything.

Haymitch nods, this is hard for him.

KATNISS
Any last advice?

HAYMITCH
Stay alive.

She goes, hugs him. He's surprised until she whispers...

KATNISS
Remember our deal...

Haymitch nods, tries to pull away, but she hangs on--

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Do whatever you can to save him.

He pulls back, looks at her, nods. They smile. He turns to the door, then stops, turns back.

HAYMITCH
Katniss. When you're in the Arena, remember who the real enemy is.

He smiles, turns, and is gone.

INT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, KATNISS'S BEDROOM - DAWN

Katniss and Peeta lie together, dressed, watching the sun rise. She takes his hand, prompting him to turn to her.

KATNISS
I don't want to be with anyone else in there. Just you.

PEETA
If that's what you want.

KATNISS
That's what I want.

A KNOCK on the door. They look at the door, then each other. He strokes her hair.

PEETA
I'll see you soon.

She nods. He gets up.

EXT. TRIBUTES QUARTERS, ROOF - DAY

Katniss and Cinna are escorted by Peacekeepers to a waiting hovercraft as its engines REV.

INT. HOVERCRAFT - DAY

Empty. Katniss and Cinna are the only passengers in the vast bay. As engines WHINE, a Peacekeeper approaches.

PEACEKEEPER
Your tracker.

Katniss holds out her arm. He injects a tracker into it. Katniss and Cinna hold hands. Katniss watches out of the window as the hovercraft takes off, rises above Panem.

EXT. CAPITOL - DAY

The Hovercraft lifts off.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - DAY

Slo-mo IMAGES of all the Tributes, arms up in solidarity.

SNOW
I want them dead, now.

PLUTARCH
Be patient.

Plutarch stands before a set of monitors showing the Tributes holding hands. Snow steps up behind him.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
They may be holding hands now... But the minute the gun goes off, it will be a bloodbath. The whole idea of revolution will be discredited.

Snow pivots to another bank of monitors showing each Tribute their pods. His eyes find Katniss with Cinna, braiding her hair.

SNOW
What about the *idea* of <u>her</u>?

PLUTARCH
(watching the screen)
The more allies she betrays, the more friends she kills, and the more she reveals her true self... she becomes just another member of the rabble.

SNOW
As long as it ends with her picture in the sky and a loud boom.

PLUTARCH
And it shall.
(starts for the door)
But let's watch her get her hands dirty first.

INT. GAMES CONTROL ROOM - DAY

The OPERATORS turn as Plutarch enters the main Control Room and takes a seat in the Head Game Maker's wing-back chair. He sits there a moment, takes it all in, then turns to an Operator--

PLUTARCH
Power up.

INT. PREP CHAMBER - POD - DAY

Katniss, nervous, hair braided, is standing in a skin-tight jumpsuit. Cinna is inspecting the fabric.

CINNA
It's light. No thermal. I'd guess desert or tropics.

INTERCOM (V.O.)
One minute to launch. One minute.

They look at each other. Katniss thinks she will never see him again. She becomes emotional.

KATNISS
Thank you for the dress...

CINNA
Thought you'd like it.

KATNISS
Cinna...

She falters, overcome. He is calm and soothing.

CINNA
Shhhhh...

He touches her lip, quieting her. He takes out her gold Mockingjay pin, fixes it to her suit. Zips up the neck of her jumpsuit securely.

CINNA (CONT'D)
Remember, girl on fire. I'm still betting on you.

He kisses her forehead, steps back as the glass cylinder slides down around her. They are inches apart. Katniss puts a hand on the glass. Cinna puts his hand over hers.

INTERCOM (V.O.)
Ten seconds.

Abruptly, two Peacekeepers burst into the room. One grabs Cinna's head and smashes it repeatedly against the glass. Cinna falls to the floor. Kicked. Blood smears the glass. She bangs against the sound-proof glass, screams silently as Cinna's unconscious body is dragged out of the room.

INTERCOM (V.O.) (CONT'D)
...five, four, three, two, one.
Launch.

INT. POD - DAY

We are with the screaming Katniss. And then with a whoosh, black and finally...

EXT. ARENA, WATER - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Silence. Katniss looks around -- shaken, crying. She's on the small disc, surrounded by water. Above her, pink sky and golden sun. A 3D hologram counts down 10, 9...

A center island holds the Cornucopia. Spokes of sand radiate out from the island into a surrounding jungle. Distantly, other Tributes are similarly stranded.

She stops sobbing. Bends, tests the water with a finger. Tastes it. Makes a face, spits it out. Salty.

CLAUDIUS
Let the 75th Hunger Games begin!

The GONG sounds. Katniss dives. Swims for her life.

EXT. CORNUCOPIA - DAY

She reaches the sand spoke, scrambles out of the water. She stops -- most of the other tributes are still stuck on their discs. Katniss sprints toward the Cornucopia.

She gets to the Cornucopia, grabs a bow and a quiver of arrows. Arms the bow.

FINNICK
Katniss...

Katniss swings around to see Finnick holding a trident. She draws the string, ready to shoot.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
The idea is to kill your <u>enemies</u>.
(holds the trident to his chest)
Not your allies.

He holds his trident so that sun GLINTS off something on his wrist. Haymitch's bangle.

KATNISS
Where'd you get that?!

FINNICK
Where d'you think?

Before Katniss can answer, FOOTSTEPS approach behind her.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Duck!!

She hits the sand as Finnick's trident flies over her head. The alcoholic Tribute from District 5 takes the trident full in the chest. He sinks to his knees, drops both swords in his hands, falls over onto the beach. Finnick goes to pull the trident out of the dead body.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Don't trust One and Two. I'll take this side. You hold them off! GO!

He disappears around the Cornucopia. Other Tributes stalk closer along the sand spokes. Katniss lets fly an arrow at Enobaria who dives back into the water. Gloss is also coming. Katniss fires an arrow that gets him in the calf. He falls backward. Finnick reappears.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
It's all weapons. Grab what you can and let's get out of here.

They rifle through the pile of weapons. Katniss grabs another quiver of arrows. Brutus comes charging at them, ROARING bloodthirstily. Finnick barely looks up.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Oh, subtle. Take care of that, will you?

Katniss fires an arrow. He holds up the belt as a shield, take the arrow in it. She loads the bow for another shot but he retreats. Finnick is armed up. Other Tributes are converging along other spokes toward the Cornucopia.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Come on!

Finnick and Katniss sprint along a spoke to the shore. They see Peeta in the water fending off a Tribute. Katniss aims her bow, can't get a shot, her view is blocked by Peeta's disk.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
I'll give him a hand.

KATNISS
No-- I'll do it.

FINNICK
Not in your condition.

KATNISS
My what--

He stops, patting her stomach.

FINNICK
Keep the rest at bay. I'll be right back.

He dives in the water. Katniss scans the beach. Now that she's left the Cornucopia, other Tributes flood in. The Career Pack forms -- Gloss, Cashmere, Brutus and Enobaria band together. Fierce hand-to-hand fighting starts. Two figures fall. The cannon BOOMS twice.

Katniss trains her bow on Finnick as she moves smoothly through the water. She could kill him. She moves the sights to the disk, where Peeta fights with the tribute. She still can't get a shot. Suddenly the splashing stops. A cannon BOOMS. A beat, and Peeta swims around toward Katniss. He's ok...

Katniss looks out to sea. Mags splashes toward her. A distant Tribute is moving down the sand toward her, axe raised to kill. Katniss looses an arrow.

A CRY as the Tribute goes down. Finnick and Peeta are now swimming smoothly through the water.

They reach the shore. Peeta runs to Katniss as Finnick turns to see Mags coming ashore.

PEETA
Guess we're not going to be alone.

KATNISS
Like it or not.

PEETA
Anyone else?

KATNISS
What about Mags?

FINNICK
Not leaving her. She's one of two people in the world who actually likes me.

He runs, scoops up the older woman, puts her on his back,

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Let's go.

They set of running toward the jungle.

KATNISS
I thought everyone liked Finnick Odair.

FINNICK
That's a different kind of like, darling.

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

They enter the jungle running pell mell, just trying to get away. It's lush, heavy. Peeta takes the lead, using a sword to hack through. A steep hill begins upward. They start climbing, breathing hard, sweating already.

FINNICK
Go, go, go! Get up high!

EXT. JUNGLE, CLEARING - DAY - MINUTES LATER

They scramble the hill in single file, exhausted, Peeta slashing through the thick undergrowth. Finnick follows, hand on his trident, carrying Mags. Katniss last, her bow ready. They're out of breath, about to collapse.

FINNICK
Okay, hold up! Hold up!

He puts down Mags, then collapses, GASPING for air. Peeta sits down hard, recovering, looking around. The jungle is thick, lush, strange -- full of colorful flowers, giant ferns, parrots and other NOISY birds.

PEETA
God, it's hot! We've got to find fresh water.

FINNICK
At least we have a head start. Half the tributes can't swim.

Suddenly, two BOOMS come from the cannon.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
I guess they aren't holding hands anymore. It's certainly no place for a woman in your condition.

She turns, gives him a scowl.

KATNISS
You think it's funny?

FINNICK
Hey, every time that cannon goes off it's music to my ears.

She threads and arrow in her bow.

KATNISS
Good to know.

Seeing this, he lifts his trident, ready. Their eyes meet.

FINNICK
You want to face the Career Pack alone? What would Haymitch say?

KATNISS
Haymitch isn't here.

As she starts to lift her bow, Peeta steps between them.

PEETA
Let's keep moving and find some water.

A long beat. Finnick gives her an admonishing grin, shakes his bangle at her.

She lowers her bow.

KATNISS
I'm not going back down there. Maybe there's water on the other side of this hill.

FINNICK
Okay. Mags?

She is looking weary, but nods.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
Come on.

And he heaves Mags onto his back again. They set off.

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

The four walk in single file, Peeta in the lead, cutting through the jungle. The top of the hill seems near.

PEETA
Anyone tracking us? Katniss?

She turns, looks back. No one's following them. Katniss turns back to Peeta. In the sky ahead, something wavering, perhaps a heat shimmer. She looks closely...

KATNISS
Peeta...!

Peeta keeps walking, swinging his knife. He half-turns.

PEETA
Yeah?

A FLASH and a sparking NOISE -- FWOOM. For a second, we see the workings of the Arena -- hydraulics, scaffolding, wires -- and beyond it, a dry prairie landscape.

Peeta flies back, smashes Katniss, sends her sprawling. His clothes are smoking slightly. She crawls over to him. Puts her face against his lips.

KATNISS
Peeta...? Peeta?!!! He's not breathing!

Suddenly, she is pushed off and Finnick sits on top of Peeta and holds his nostrils closed.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
No!

She whips an arrow into her bow, aims, then freezes. Strangely, Finnick is kissing Peeta. Or blowing air into his lungs. Then, Finnick's fist pounds Peeta's chest, again and again, as he tries to restart Peeta's heart.

INT. GAMES CONTROL ROOM - DAY

Everyone stares at the main screen. Around the room, monitors show different angles of Finnick and Peeta. Plutarch in his Head Gamemaker chair, flips through a cover-flow view of the Arena's various camera angles.

PLUTARCH
Cannon ready.

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

Katniss stares. Finnick has his ear to Peeta's chest.

FINNICK
We got something.

KATNISS
Peeta?

A cough. Peeta's eyes open. She goes, hugs him tightly. Finnick slumps back, relieved. Peeta sits up weakly.

PEETA
Careful. There's a force field up ahead.

She laughs and cries at the same time, hugging him tight. Finnick watches, quizzical -- seeing the depth of her feelings for him, realizing it's not all just an act.

INT. PRESIDENT SNOW'S QUARTERS - DAY

Snow sits watching the Games in his den with his Granddaughter. Two GUARDS stand at the door in the background. Snow sees the same thing Finnick did.

GRANDDAUGHTER
Someday, I want to love someone that much.

He studies her a moment, realizes just how much power these two have. He finally smiles at the girl...

SNOW
And someday you shall.

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

Katniss recovers her composure, wiping Peeta's face.

KATNISS
You were dead.

PEETA
How dead?

KATNISS
Your heart stopped.

PEETA
Seems to be working now.

Katniss turns, looks hard at Finnick. Why did he save Peeta? Finnick gives her a tired smile, gets up.

FINNICK
Can you walk?

PEETA
Sure.

Peeta gets to his feet. Collapses. Manages to stand up.

PEETA (CONT'D)
I'm ok... I'm ok.

FINNICK
We're exposed here. Now water. Let's see if we can work our way around it.

He leads them off.

EXT. JUNGLE, CLEARING - DAY

Katniss is leading; Peeta limping, Mags just slow. Every few steps, Katniss throws some nuts at the force field. They sizzle, fly back. Mags stops to pick them up, eats them.

PEETA
Mags. They might be poisonous.

Mags just shrugs.

FINNICK
Guess we'll find out.

Katniss sees a tree arching up above the clearing.

KATNISS
Just a second...!

EXT. JUNGLE, CLEARING / TREE TOP - DAY

She loops her bow over her shoulder, goes and scurries up the trunk until she's above the tree line. The whole Arena is finally visible -- a giant bowl of jungle with the water and Cornucopia at the center. She looks up. Above her, another fuzzy FLAW is just barely visible.

She takes out an arrow, threads it, fires it straight up into the sky. A brief FLASH and spark shower as it hits and -- in a FLICKER -- reveals the dome-like structure of the entire force field above her. She turns, looks back out over the whole Arena. There's no way out. She slides down the tree, approaches the others.

KATNISS
It's a dome. The force field. This is the top of the Arena. We're closed in.

FINNICK
It's going to be dark soon. I think we're safe with our back protected. Let's camp. Take turns sleeping.

KATNISS
I don't think so.

FINNICK
Honey, that thing I just did with Peeta? That was called *saving his life.*
(then)
If I'd wanted to kill either of you, I'd have done it by now.

He goes to help Mags. Katniss turns to join Peeta and lies down next to him, her eyes open, alert.

KATNISS
You should get some rest. I'll keep watch.

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

Finnick is on guard -- eyes alert, trident ready.

The national anthem of Panem BOOMS. They all look up. Across the vault of the sky are displayed the faces of the fallen Tributes. First the drunkard from District Five. The Male Morphling. Cecilia and Woof. The Male and Female from 9. The Female from 10. And Seeder, from District 11. Eight Tributes in all. Katniss looks over.

KATNISS
Eight?

Finnick nods. Katniss leaves Peeta, joins Finnick.

FINNICK
How is he?

KATNISS
He's ok, just dehydrated like the rest of us.

As if on cue, a silver parachute floats down into the clearing. Finnick scrambles to it. Unscrews the tube, pulls out a silver object. Tube-shaped. And a note.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
"Drink up."

FINNICK
What is it?

Katniss examines it, frowning. She turns it over, blows in it, stares, trying to understand... Then she gets it.

KATNISS
A spile!

She gets up, starts hacking the tree with Peeta's sword. She sticks the spile into the hole in the tree, holds her palm beneath it. A drop, two drops. She licks her palm.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Water!

A steady, thin trickle begins to pour. QUICK CUTS -- Mags drinks. Peeta drinks. Katniss drinks. Finnick too. Finnick finishes drinking from a leaf-woven basket, exhales loudly. He looks around. Mags sits against a tree, nodding out.

FINNICK
I'll take the first two hours. You get some sleep. Katniss...? Sweet dreams.

She gives him a look, turns and goes into the shelter. She lies down next to Peeta, but doesn't close her eyes. Her bow, threaded with an arrow, clutched to her chest.

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

A great TOLLING bell. Katniss sits up. Peeta's still asleep. She exits the shelter, joins Finnick, looking up at the sky, listening. One, two, on and on. Then silence.

KATNISS
I counted twelve.

FINNICK
Midnight?

KATNISS
Or the number of Districts?

They look at each other. No answer. A muffled CRACKLE of electricity. Abruptly, LIGHTNING strikes a tall tree in the distance -- a huge, cataclysmic strike -- lighting up the whole tree, power surging off it. A lightning storm begins. Katniss shrugs.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I'll take the next watch.

Finnick nods, goes to join the others in the shelter. Katniss sits, trims feathers of her arrows. Eyes blink.

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

LATER -- Katniss snaps awake. She sits up, panicked at having slept on watch. Looks around. Everything calm. Somewhere nearby it is RAINING. She looks up, holds a hand out. Nothing. It stays dry. Looks around -- strange. Then, abruptly, the sound of the RAIN stops.

An eerie quiet. Just her BREATHING. She turns. A wall of fog drifts down the hillside toward them. She watches it come, curious. Tendrils of mist grow close. She reaches out to touch it... And yanks back, stung.

KATNISS
Ahhh...!

Her hand BLISTERS. She realizes what's happening.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Run! Get up! Let's go! Run!!!

She stumbles up, runs to the shelter, grabs Peeta.

FINNICK
What is it?

KATNISS
Poison gas!

Finnick picks up Mags. Katniss helps Peeta. They run as fast as they can, stumbling over tree roots, getting caught in vines. But the fog keeps coming, tendrils reaching out toward them. Katniss trips, falls down. Looks up. A fog tendril reaches out. Peeta comes back, yanks Katniss away, but he himself gets stung by the fog. He CRIES OUT, stumbles away. She takes his hand.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Come on!

They race down hill, but he is half-blind, limping hard.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
We've got to go faster.

But he's tiring. The fog is closing. A tendril brushes him. Skin on the back of his hands suddenly blisters. A tendril stings her. Blotches break out on her face.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Head for the water.

Katniss staggers under the weight of Peeta but stumbles on. She falls. Gets up, carries on down the hillside. Finnick is ahead, struggling with Mags on his back. Katniss catches up, helping Peeta, then falls again.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
My arms. Won't work. Gas.

Finnick looks between Peeta and Mags, gasping for breath.

FINNICK
I can't...! I can only carry one of you!

Suddenly Mags goes to Finnick. She kisses him. Then she turns, walks up into the fog. She is consumed by the thick cloud and falls, body jerking spasmodically.

FINNICK (CONT'D)
No!

The cannon BOOMS. The fog drifts inexorably toward them.

Finnick, blind with grief, lifts Peeta, drags him down the hill, just before the fog reaches them. We are at ground level, seeing through the blur of Katniss's eyes. None of them can walk anymore. They crawl like animals, but not fast enough. Their faces and hands are blistered and scarred. They are choking, blistered, half-blind.

They tumble down a dirt ravine into a clearing. Can't move. Katniss turns. The fog descends, unstoppable. They're doomed. She waits for the end. Then, strangely, the fog stops, as if blocked by an invisible wall.

KATNISS
Stopped. Look...!

Peeta and Finnick turn. Somehow, the fog begins to be sucked back up the hill, leaving Mags's body behind. They watch it disappear. Katniss fops onto her back.

POV -- Above, in the jungle canopy, two colorful monkeys gaze down at them, curious.

She turns. They are yards from a brackish lagoon.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
The water.

They begin to crawl, limp, struggle down the slope.

EXT. LAGOON, ARENA - CONTINUOUS

Peeta, Katniss and Finnick drag themselves to the shore of the lagoon. Katniss puts her arm in the water, stifles a scream and withdraws it. A phosphorescent, green gas hisses off her arm. The blisters close impossibly fast.

KATNISS
Peeta! Come on!

She plunges in the lagoon, steeling herself against the pain. Peeta crawls up, slides into the water, writhes in agony, but the gas hisses out of his skin and evaporates into the air. It's working. He laughs with relief.

Finnick lies motionless on the dirt. Katniss and Peeta take his arms, drag him into the water. He comes to life, thrashing, splashing and YELLING in agony. But he heals. Katniss stands up in the water. Finnick croaks.

FINNICK
Water... For our throats...! We can't drink this...!

PEETA
You got the spile?

She hands it to him. He gets up, heads for the jungle.

EXT. JUNGLE, ARENA - NIGHT

Peeta digs a hole in the trunk of a tree with his sword.

EXT. LAGOON, ARENA - NIGHT

Finnick sits up. Looks back up the hill, puzzled. They are both waist-deep in the lagoon.

FINNICK
The fog. Just stopped. Like there was a barrier. You see that?

She nods. Sits up, looks around at the whole Arena.

KATNISS
Can't die all at once. They need variety in their show.

He doesn't respond. She turns and freezes.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Finnick.

FINNICK
What is it?

KATNISS
Monkeys. In the canopy. Fifteen feet above him. You can see their eyes.

She looks. Everywhere, glinting in the moonlight, pairs of eyes flit silently from tree to tree. Her face falls. She stands, picks up her bow, threads and arrow. Calls...

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Peeta?

PEETA
Yea?

He turns, sees the monkeys, sizes up the situation.

KATNISS
Walk back slow. Keep your sword up.

She takes aim, but the monkeys disappear from view. She looks for a target but finds none. Then, ominously, they HEAR bushes SHAKE and the SNORTS and SHRIEKS of monkeys.

She turns. The brush all around the lagoon TREMBLES and SHAKES. They are surrounded. Her eyes dart, panicked.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Get to the beach!

A SHRIEK and the monkeys attack en masse, storming out of the jungle, shrieking and baring teeth. They are MUTTS -- muscular bodies, deadly teeth and sharp talons.

Peeta backs up, brandishing his sword, keeping them at bay. They HISS, bare their teeth, advance on him. And Alpha mutt leaps at him. Katniss shoots an arrow that kills the animal mid-air. More mutts advance. Peeta hacks at them with his sword. Katniss fires arrow after arrow.

Finnick throws a quiver of arrows to Katniss, unslings his trident and expertly spears them as they leap at him. Peeta reaches them, and they form a triangle, defending each other's backs, holding off the hordes...

The mutts aren't sophisticated fighters, but they are ferocious, terrifying and there are so many of them...

Katniss runs out of arrows, starts swinging her bow at them. One Mutt goes for her, knocking her back underwater. The Mutt comes after her, snapping at her face.

She holds it back with her bow. Peeta stabs it. Katniss bursts out of the water, GASPING. Peeta's sword gets stuck. He's defenseless. Another mutt charges...

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Peeta...!

The mutt leaps, mouth agape, talons stretched for his neck. The jungle seems to move in the shape of a person.

The Morphling -- painted in perfect jungle camouflage -- throws herself between the mutt and Peeta. The mutt sinks its jaws into her neck. She CRIES out and falls. Peeta frees his sword, stabs the mutt. It falls. He drags the Morphling out onto the sandy beach.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - DAWN

Katniss and Finnick stand guard against the mutts, who SCREAM and bare their teeth, but don't charge again.

The Morphling's breathing is labored, terror on her face -- she is dying. Peeta crouches beside her, takes her hand, she looks up at him. He keeps his voice soft:

PEETA
Hey. You want to see something?

He moves his face so she can see that the dark sky above has become an aurora borealis of pinks and orange hues as dawn comes.

PEETA (CONT'D)
Incredible, isn't it? All those colors. That's where the real action is. Up there.
(sits beside her)
You just watch the sky. Don't worry about anything else. I'll be right here with you.

The Morphling smiles. Then she nods forward, lifeless. Peeta closes her eyes. The cannon BOOMS. The mutts stop screaming. Finnick and Katniss look at each other.

FINNICK
Guess they got what they wanted.

EXT. SHORE - DAWN

Peeta has carried the Morphling into the ocean and gently lays her body in the sea, letting it float away. Finnick and Katniss stand on the shore, watching grimly.

KATNISS
I'm sorry about Mags.

FINNICK
She was never going to make it.

He walks off. Peeta wades out of the water. Katniss puts a hand on his back. Peeta looks at Finnick as he walks away.

PEETA
Mags?

Katniss nods.

KATNISS
She saved all of us.

They both see Finnick now sitting alone on the beach, facing the water, head bowed.

PEETA
She walked right into the fog.

KATNISS
Finnick saved you too.

This catches him off guard. He nods.

A hovercraft appears over the water. A metal claw comes down from it, picks up the Morphling. They watch as the claw retracts and the Hovercraft disappears. Peeta motions to the Morphling.

PEETA
That woman saved my life. I didn't even know her name.

KATNISS
You think she sacrificed herself?

PEETA
...To keep me alive? I don't know. Sure looked that way.

They look at each other. She turns, looks at the sea.

KATNISS
Doesn't make any sense.

EXT. SHORE - DAY

They are eating raw fish with their fingers. Finnick's trident has a fish still freshly-speared on it. Finnick warily surveys the jungle Arena.

FINNICK
I don't know about you, but I'm not in any hurry to go back in that jungle.

Peeta opens an oyster, laughs.

PEETA
Hey. Look...!

He holds up a pearl. He washes it off, hands it to her.

PEETA (CONT'D)
For you.

Drops it in her hand. She gazes at it. Looks up.

KATNISS
Thank you.

He meets her eyes -- full of sadness and affection. She tucks the pearl away. She takes his hand, squeezes.

A distant SCREAM. They spring up, alert. A deep RUMBLE. Suddenly, across the Arena, a huge wave crests the hill and crashes down the slop, topping trees. It collides with the "ocean", creating a tsunami-like wave.

PEETA
That's new.

KATNISS
Get back! Get back!

They grab their weapons and retreat up the beach as the wave surges, carrying away much of their stuff. A cannon BOOMS. As water recedes, a hovercraft appears in the distance and plucks a dead body from a tree.

PEETA
(watching)
I already miss the monkeys...

Katniss looks up. Figures approach along the beach.

KATNISS
Someone's coming.

Instinctively, they back up into the brush along the shore, crouching to stay hidden.

EXT. SHORE - MINUTES LATER

Katniss can make out three figures now. One looks half-deranged, splashing in the sea: Wiress. Another tries to get her out, dragging, cajoling: Johanna. Beetee looks spent. He is carrying a large spool of wire. They are all covered in red liquid. Finnick's face lights up.

FINNICK
Johanna!

JOHANNA
(distant)
Finnick!

Finnick emerges from the foliage, runs toward the trio.

KATNISS
Now what?

PEETA
Guess we got more allies.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - DAY

Katniss and Peeta approach the three Tributes, who are soaked in blood. Beetee sits in the sand, nursing an injured leg. Wiress seems dazed, repeating some sort of mantra. Johanna is talking very fast with Finnick.

WIRESS
Tick, tock, tick, tock...

JOHANNA
Rain started. Thought it was water at first. Turned out to be blood. Thick and hot. We were choking, staggering around blind. That's when Blight hit the force field.
(shakes her head)
He wasn't much, but he was from home.

KATNISS
What's wrong with her?

BEETEE
She's in shock. Dehydration isn't helping.

WIRESS
Tick, tock, tick, tock...

Wiress sidles up to Johanna, who roughly shoves her away.

JOHANNA
Just stay down!

KATNISS
Lay off her!

She pushes Johanna away. Johanna slaps Katniss, furious.

JOHANNA
I got her out for *you*!

Finnick grabs Johanna and pulls her into the water as she yells and curses. Katniss jumps up to go after Johanna. Peeta hods her back.

PEETA
Whoa, whoa, whoa...!

KATNISS
What does that mean? For me?

PEETA
You *did* want them as allies.

WIRESS
Tock, tick, tock, tick, tock...

Katniss looks at them. They are sweet, decent people, in need of help. She smiles wearily to herself.

KATNISS
C'mon. Let's get you cleaned up.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - LATER

Peeta and Finnick are resting on the beach. Katniss is in the water, washing blood off Wiress. Beetee, cleaned up, is rinsing blood off his coil of wire. Johanna, clean, is at the shore, on watch, holding her axe. In the distance, we can HEAR insects CLICKING noisily.

WIRESS
Tick, tock, tick, tock...

KATNISS
Tick, tock, I know.

She smiles reassuringly. Beetee finishes cleaning his coil, turns, walks up the beach, joining the other men.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
What's he got there?

JOHANNA
The coil? Some kind of wire.

KATNISS
Cornucopia?

JOHANNA
Took a knife in the back to get it.

They watch him sit, dry off his coil. Johanna turns.

JOHANNA (CONT'D)
How'd you lose Mags?

KATNISS
The fog. I guess she felt she was slowing us down. She kissed him and walked right into it.

JOHANNA
She was Finnick's mentor. Half his family, basically.

Wiress gets up and comes over to them, relentless.

WIRESS
Tick, tock, tick, tock...

JOHANNA
I can't take it anymore. You and Nuts can guard. I'm going to sleep.

She walks back up the beach, lies down near the men. Katniss finishes washing up Wiress, who smiles, grateful.

KATNISS
There you go. Almost done.

Katniss looks up at the sun.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Must be Noon. Sun's overhead.

Abruptly, the insect CLICKING stops. Sudden silence. A muffled CRACKLE in the air. Then, in the distance, LIGHTNING strikes the same tree as the previous night. Even in daylight, from afar, the power is awesome.

WIRESS
Tick, tock, tick, tock...

KATNISS
Yeah yeah... tick tock...

Then she tops. Her eyes dart around the Arena. She quickly stands up, looks at the whole circular layout. Looks at Wiress. Back to the arena. Smiles...

KATNISS (CONT'D)
It's a clock...

EXT. CORNUCOPIA - DAY

SWEEPING AERIAL SHOT -- Katniss has led everyone out to the Cornucopia, a wreckage of abandoned weapons and bloodied sand. They are all armed, tense. Katniss points out the twelve spoked sections of jungle.

KATNISS
It starts with the lightning. Then Blood rain. Fog. Monkeys. Those are the first four hours. At ten, the wave comes from over there. Then the insects start.

JOHANNA
And the other six hours?

KATNISS
I'm sure we'll find out.

WIRESS
Tick, tock! Tick, tock!

FINNICK
Wiress, you're a genius.

Wiress smiles, claps. She wanders to the water, singing "Hickory Dickery Dock". Peeta points at the Cornucopia.

PEETA
Look. The tail points to twelve.

He uses his knife to draw a wide circle in the sand, divides it into sections, labels them. Katniss points.

KATNISS
The lightning strikes at Noon and Midnight.

BEETEE
Strikes where?

KATNISS
That big tree.

He stares off at it, smiles to himself.

BEETEE
Good.

He adjusts the coil of wire he is carrying. Peeta finishes labelling his sand map. He gestures.

PEETA
So twelve to one, lightning. One to two, blood. Then fog. Monkeys.

KATNISS
And ten to eleven, the wave... Eleven to twelve, insects. What else. You guys see anything?

JOHANNA
Just a lot of blood.

PEETA
It doesn't matter. The threats happen on an hourly basis. As long as we steer clear of whatever sector is active, we'll be safe.

FINNICK
Relatively speaking.

He winks at Katniss when off-screen, Wiress's nursery SONG stops suddenly. Katniss turns, just in time to see Gloss emerge from the water, slit Wiress's throat.

EVERYTHING HAPPENS AT ONCE:

She lifts her bow, fires an arrow through Gloss's temple. Johanna spins, throws an ax into the chest of an onrushing Cashmere. Brutus flings a spear at Peeta. Finnick deflects it.

Enobaria throws a knife into Finnick's shoulder. He crumples. Brutus and Enobaria turn and flee around the Cornucopia. Katniss and Johanna begin chasing them.

INT. GAMES CONTROL ROOM - DAY

Plutarch watches the chase on a 3D model that REVEALS the clock-like structure of the whole Arena, and the horrors associated with each wedge.

CONSOLE OPERATOR
They've figured out the clock.

PLUTARCH
So they have.

He turns to a console Operator.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Spin it.
(Operator hesitates)
Let's shake it up. Spin it.

The Operator touches a console button.

EXT. CORNUCOPIA - DAY

Suddenly, the whole world seems to begin spinning. The fighters fall or stop running, losing their balance.

The entire island of the Cornucopia spins increasingly fast, churning up huge waves and sprays of water.

Katniss and Johanna fall to the ground. Nearby, Peeta, Finnick and Beetee fall too. Katniss looks up, sees Brutus and Enobaria escaping -- running into the jungle.

Centrifugal force begins to kick in. Everyone grabs onto rocks, holding tight. Inside the Cornucopia, equipment cases and loose weapons slide up against the walls, then spill out, flung out toward the water. Peeta ducks as swords, knives and other weapons are flung past him.

Katniss loses her grip, slides to the edge of the spinning island. She lunges, grabbing an outcropping, her legs dragging in the frothing water.

Beetee can't hold on, starts to slide. Finnick tries to grab him, misses. Beetee is flung into the roiling water. Finnick turns, yells to Peeta.

FINNICK
You okay?

Peeta nods. Finnick lets go and dives after Beetee.

Katniss slips. Johanna grabs her hand, holding her. Their grip slips... And breaks. Katniss is flung outward and tossed into the water.

INT. GAMES CONTROL ROOM - DAY

On the holographic display, the "Katniss Everdeen" avatar lands in the water. Plutarch sees this. He watches it a moment, looks at the other avatars, sees that he's indeed *shaken them all up* and nods, pleased.

PLUTARCH
Okay, that's enough.

He sits back.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
Let's see how they *tell time* *now*.

EXT. CORNUCOPIA - DAY

The spinning island begins to slow. Waves decrease.

Katniss sees the island slow, swims toward it. The island slows to a stop. Peeta and Johanna sit up, spent.

Katniss climbs up on the shore, gets unsteadily to her feet. Finnick helps Beetee ashore, spitting water.

Three CANNONS boom out. Peeta and Johanna stand up.

PEETA
You okay?

KATNISS
Think so. Everyone? All okay?

Nods from the others. They gather, dazed and bewildered. Johanna turns.

JOHANNA
Let's get off this stinking island.

EXT. BEACH - DAY

Katniss, Peeta and the others step onto the beach.

KATNISS
Besides Brutus and Enobaria, who's left?

PEETA
Chaff. Just those three.

Finnick tosses his trident into the sand. Beetee sits, pulls out his coil, looks at the thin wire, brows knit.

FINNICK
They know they're outnumbered. I doubt they'll attack again. We're safer on the beach.

JOHANNA
Means we have to go hunt them down.

BEETEE
No. There is a better way to kill them.

Suddenly, a SHRIEK of terror and pain. They freeze. It comes again. Katniss stops, white with fear.

KATNISS
Prim? Prim, where are you?!

The terrified cry comes again. Katniss runs toward it.

FINNICK
Wait! Katniss!

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

Katniss runs into the jungle. The cries get more frequent, more desperate. Katniss stops in a clearing, head darting, trying to find the source of the cries.

KATNISS
Prim!

Then she sees above her -- a Jabberjay. It SCREAMS. She threads an arrow in her bow, aims. It tries to fly. She kills it. She goes, gets her arrow. Finnick arrives.

FINNICK
You okay?

KATNISS
It's just a--...

Another SCREAM -- a young woman. Finnick is electrified. He takes off. Katniss runs after him, following his trail. Finds him circling a large tree, looking up.

FINNICK
Annie...! Annie...! Annie!!!

KATNISS
It's not her! It's a Jabberjay.
They're playing a trick!

She goes to comfort him, but he spins on her.

FINNICK
How do you think they got that
sound? Jabberjays *copy*!

She stares -- realizing what he's saying. Then a new CRY rings out. Gale. She stares, horrified.

KATNISS
Gale...!

FINNICK
No. Come on!

She tries to run. He grabs her, pulls her down the hill. They stumble back down the trail until they see Peeta and Johanna, their hands raised, mouths moving silently.

Katniss and Finnick smack into an invisible wall. She recovers, presses her hands up against it -- matching Peeta's hands. He talks urgently. She can't hear him.

Then the birds arrive. One Jabberjay after another, screaming in the voices of Prim, Gale, and Annie. They swarm chaotically around Katniss and Finnick, diving at them, beating their wings, shrieking in their faces.

It's overwhelming. Finnick throws rocks at them. Katniss shoots arrows. It's too much. The cacophony becomes unbearable. Finnick, then Katniss, cover their ears with their hands and collapses in the fetal position.

CLOSE ON -- Katniss. Crying, eyes shut, hands over ears.

EXT. JUNGLE - DAY - LATER

Silence. Katniss opens her eyes. She is on the jungle floor, dazed. Sits up. Finnick is nearby, recovering. Peeta runs to comfort her. Beetee and Johanna follow.

PEETA
It's electronic. They can do
anything. But--
(turns her face to his)
--they can't hurt Prim.

JOHANNA
Your *fiancee* is right. The whole country loves your sister. If they tortured her, did anything to her, forget the districts-- there'd be riots in the damn Capitol. Hey--
(yells upward)
How's that sound, Snow?! How bout we light your back yard on fire! You can't put everybody in here!

Katniss looks up, shocked. Johanna shakes her head.

JOHANNA (CONT'D)
They can't hurt me. There's no one left I love.
(then)
I'll get you some water.

She walks off. Beetee sits next to her, drained.

BEETEE
Well... Now we know what happens at four o'clock.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - DAY

They emerge from the jungle, survey the beach. Empty. Katniss sits wearily, lays her bow down. Peeta lies back, exhausted. Beetee sits nearby, looking intently at his wire, the jungle, the beach. Finnick dives in the water. Johanna approaches with a cup of water and some arrows.

JOHANNA
Here.

KATNISS
Thank you.

She drinks. Johanna sits next to her, returns the arrows to Katniss's quiver. Katniss looks at Finnick swimming.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Who's Annie?

JOHANNA
Annie Cresta. The girl Mags volunteered for. She won five years ago.

KATNISS
The one who kind of... lost it?

JOHANNA
(looks at Katniss)
Love is weird.

Katniss turns and looks at Finnick again, in a new light. Beetee lifts his head, looks at Johanna and Katniss.

BEETEE
I have a plan.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - MINUTES LATER

They have all gathered. Beetee is presenting the others with his plan, like a professor teaching school children.

BEETEE
If you were the Careers, where would you feel safe? The jungle?

JOHANNA
The jungle's a nightmare.

PEETA
Right here. On the beach.

BEETEE
And why are they not here?

JOHANNA
Because we are. We claimed it. And we outnumber them.

BEETEE
But if we left, they would come.

FINNICK
Or stay hidden, in the treeline.

BEETEE
Which will soon be soaked with water from the ten o'clock wave.
(they all nod)
What happens at Noon and Midnight?

KATNISS
The lightning strikes the big tree.

BEETEE
Here is what I propose...

CUT AWAYS:

-- PLUTARCH, IN THE GAME CONTROL ROOM, WATCHES PENSIVELY

-- SNOW, IN HIS DEN, WATCHES INTRIGUED.

-- HAYMITCH, IN TRIBUTE QUARTERS, LEANS FORWARD, WORRIED.

-- PRIM AND HER MOTHER WATCH -- FRIGHTENED, BREATHLESS

BEETEE (TV)
...We leave the beach at dusk. I expect they will take our place. Prior to midnight, we run this wire from the tree to the water...

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - DAY

They listen to Beetee -- intrigued but skeptical.

BEETEE
...When the lightning strikes at Midnight, anyone in the water, or on damp sand, will be electrocuted.

They all look at each other -- can this possibly work?

JOHANNA
How do you know the wire won't just burn up?

BEETEE
Because I invented it. Trust me, it will not burn up.

Again, everyone looks at each other. Katniss shrugs.

KATNISS
Why not? If it fails, no harm done.

PEETA
I say we try.

Finnick looks to Johanna. They make eye contact. Katniss sees this, frowns. Johanna shrugs.

JOHANNA
Better than hunting them down.

FINNICK
(to Beetee)
So what can we do to help you?

BEETEE
Just keep me alive for the next six hours.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - SUNSET

On the beach, Finnick and Johanna are fishing with his net and trident. Beetee, near them, fiddles with his wire. Katniss says quietly:

KATNISS
I think it's time we took off.

He glances at the others. Shakes his head.

PEETA
I think his plan will work.

KATNISS
I do too. And once the Careers are dead, we both know what happens next.

He turns to her. He knows.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
I don't want to be the one who shoots first.

Peeta is quiet, frustrated, searching for a way out. He nods toward Finnick and the others.

PEETA
What if they don't either? What if we all refuse to shoot first?

KATNISS
We'd still end up dead.

PEETA
Maybe not. It's what we did last time.

KATNISS
They won't make that mistake again. Look, you know and I know...

INT. SNOW'S OFFICE - DUSK

Snow watching Katniss.

KATNISS (TV)
...Only one person is walking out of here. One winner...

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - CONTINUOUS

KATNISS
...That's going to be one of us.

He nods, looks away -- convinced but not happy about it.

PEETA
The Careers are still out there. We're safe with these guys 'til Midnight. If we hear two cannons then, we leave.

She thinks this over. Reluctantly nods. As she turns to go...

PEETA (CONT'D)
Katniss...
(she pauses)
I don't know what kind of deal you made with Haymitch, but... He made me promises too.
(then)
He can't save us <u>both</u>.

She shrugs, tries to downplay it.

KATNISS
I'm not sure he can save either one of us. I mean, where's he been? So far the games have begun, we've gotten one *spile* and that's it. Where is he?

PEETA
You know what I'm saying.
(then)
If you die. And I live. I would have nothing. No one I care about. You're my whole life.

KATNISS
Peeta--

He takes a gold locket from around his neck.

PEETA
For you it's different.

CLOSE ON THE LOCKET as he opens it to reveal photos of Prim. Her Mother. Gale.

PEETA (CONT'D)
Your family needs you. You have to live. For them.

The photos bring tears to her eyes. She turns.

KATNISS
What about you?

He smiles and gently shrugs, without any self-pity.

PEETA
No one needs me.

She looks at him, almost seeing him for the first time.

KATNISS
I do. I need you.

He turns -- not quite believing this. She leans in and kisses him -- the first passionate kiss of her life.

When she breaks, he starts to object and she quiets him again. Finally, he just kisses back. Then he takes his locket off, puts it around her neck. She smiles. She locks in his eyes, touches his face, kisses him again.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Snow enters as Plutarch is getting ready to leave.

PLUTARCH
President Snow. Just in time.

Snow looks at the screen, indicates Katniss, kissing Peeta.

SNOW
She's preparing him to fight.

PLUTARCH
That's our girl.

SNOW
This is what you predicted.

PLUTARCH
By midnight she'll be up to her lips in the blood of those who've kept her and Peeta alive.
(MORE)

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
And that will be the end of the people's love affair with Katniss Everdeen.

SNOW
Moves and counter moves.

PLUTARCH
Indeed.

Plutarch smiles. He indicates a bottle of champagne and two glasses behind the glass of a small fridge.

PLUTARCH (CONT'D)
We'll toast when it's done. In the meantime--
(indicates his chair)
--make yourself comfortable...

Snow keeps watching, Plutarch walks past and exits. Snow moves to the glass wall and looks down at THE CONTROL ROOM BELOW, watches as now Plutarch enters.

EXT. BEACH, ARENA - NIGHT

They are packing up, clearing out.

BEETEE
Take everything. They are surely watching us.

EXT. JUNGLE, ARENA - NIGHT

They hike up the hill. Beetee uses a wood walking stick. Suddenly, the ANTHEM booms. They turn. In the sky, faces APPEAR -- Cashmere, Gloss, Wiress, Mags, the Female from 5, the Female Morphling, Blight, and the Male from 10. The group watches as the last faces fade.

KATNISS
Eight dead.

JOHANNA
They really burned through us.

Katniss and Peeta share a look. They soldier on.

EXT. JUNGLE, LIGHTNING TREE - NIGHT

Exhausted, they reach the tall tree at the summit of the Arena. Beetee takes out his wire, examines the tree.

BEETEE
No sign of charring. Must be some sort of conductor.

Suddenly, not far away, the insects start CLICKING loudly. Everyone looks over, wary. They trade glances.

KATNISS
The insects. That means it's eleven. We have exactly one hour.

He lays out a length of extra wire, then hands Katniss the wire, takes the coil and begins circling the tree.

BEETEE
Let's get this wrapped up.

EXT. JUNGLE, LIGHTNING TREE - NIGHT

Beetee finishes fastening his knife to his walking stick (using vines) as Katniss explains the lightning strike. Peeta, Finnick and Johanna listen. Behind them, the tree is wrapped in Beetee's wire. Insects are still CLICKING.

KATNISS
...When the insects stop clicking, you'll hear the air start to crackle. You'll have about ten seconds 'til the lightning strikes.

Beetee looks up from his home-made spear. To the others:

BEETEE
Typically, it is 5 billion joules of energy. You don't want to be anywhere near here when it hits.

d. Beetee hands the coil to Johanna.

BEETEE (CONT'D)
You girls go together. Unspool carefully. Make sure the coil is in the water. Head for the tree in the two o'clock sector. We'll meet there.

Katniss and Peeta exchange a concerned look.

PEETA
I'll go as a guard.

BEETEE
I need you here to protect me. And the tree.

PEETA
Katniss is pregnant. I want to go with her.

BEETEE
There are two Careers out there. I need two guards.

PEETA
Finnick can guard you.

Beetee hesitates, looks at Peeta over his glasses.

BEETEE
You agreed to keep me alive until Midnight.

FINNICK
Is there a problem here?

An awkward stand off. Katniss breaks it.

KATNISS
No. We're good.

Peeta is uneasy. Katniss goes and gives him a long kiss.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
See you at midnight.

JOHANNA
Let's go, lover. I'll start. You be look-out.

She starts unravelling the wire. Katniss pulls an arrow from her quiver, threads her bow, follows Johanna off.

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

QUICK CUTS -- They move fast down hill. Johanna lets the coil unspool. Katniss is on guard, bow ready to shoot.

It is dark, claustrophobic, spooky -- impossible to see more than a few yards through the dense shadowy jungle.

Johanna stops a moment, glancing around, speaking sotto.

JOHANNA
This is taking too long.

KATNISS
I'll take over.

JOHANNA
Let's move. I want to put some distance between that beach and me. Frying is not the way I want to go.

Katniss shoulders her bow, takes the coil. They move on down the hill again, Katniss unreeling the wire. Abruptly, the thin wire springs toward them, bunching in tangled loops, going slack. Katniss stops, confused.

KATNISS
Something's...

Panicked, she drops the coil, reaches for an arrow. Before she can arm herself, Johanna picks up the coil, smashes Katniss in the head.

Katniss falls, stunned, Johanna gets on top of her, takes out a knife and gouges Katniss's arm. Blood pours out. Up the hill, two distant Figures CRASH down through the jungle toward them. Katniss GROANS. Katniss hisses.

JOHANNA
Stay down.

She smears blood from Katniss's arm all over her face. The FIGURES approach and emerge from the foliage -- Enobaria and Brutus, carrying swords.

They stop-- Johanna is standing over a bloodied Katniss, holding a bloodied knife. Johanna stands and flings her knife at them. Brutus deflects it with his spear. Johanna, unarmed, turns and runs off into the knight.

Brutus and Enobaria head off down the hill after her. Beat. Katniss groans, gets to her feet. Touches her bloodied arm. She looks up the hill, trying hard to focus.

KATNISS
Peeta...?

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

Katniss -- bloody, dazed -- begins searching her bow. Another FIGURE comes CRASHING down through the jungle.

Katniss ducks out of his path, just as Finnick runs past, trident ready. He sees the tangle of wires, stops. He swipes his hand on a leaf, getting blood on his fingers.

He turns, looking around wildly, whispering loudly.

FINNICK
Johanna...! Katniss...!

Katniss, terrified, sinks down, says nothing. Finnick runs off, bounding down the hill. Katniss finds her bow and quiver. She stands, unsteady.

QUICK CUTS -- She uses moss and a vine to tie up the wound in her arm.

She begins climbing the hill again. She finds the wire, tangled in the bushes, and follows it up the hill.

Suddenly, up the hill, there is a distant FLASH of LIGHT and a muffled, familiar FWOOM -- the sound of the force field zapping someone.

Katniss stops, frowning, unsure of what just happened. She redoubles her effort, scrambling up the hill.

EXT. JUNGLE, LIGHTNING TREE - NIGHT

Katniss, stumbling, breathing hard, reaches the lightning tree. No one's there. She looks desperately.

KATNISS
Peeta...! Peeta...!!!

No response. The wire wrapped around the tree leads up the hill. She follows it to...

Beetee on the ground, unconscious. He's breathing. Nearby is his handmade spear, wrapped up in wire. She picks it up.

She turns and looks up -- the force field FLAW shimmers.

She looks back at Beetee, then again at the wire-wrapped knife/spear in her hand -- what was he trying to do?

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Snow watches Katniss. He leans forward, concerned.

EXT. JUNGLE, ARENA - NIGHT

A cannon BOOMS. She spins. What the hell is happening? Another BOOOM. Now she's hysterical, fearing the worst.

KATNISS
Peeta...!

Then, distantly, she hears Peeta calling her name.

PEETA (O.C.)
Katniss...! Katniss!!!

She turns. He's too far away. She looks around, terrified he's given himself away. She screams, too loudly.

KATNISS
Peeta! Peeta, I'm here! Peeta!!!

She stops, listens. His voice is distant but clear.

PEETA (O.C.)
Get away from the tree! Katniss!
The lightning...! Move away!

She glances at the tree -- only a few yards away. Then, in the jungle below, another FIGURE comes CRASHING up the hill toward her. Her eyes widen in terror. She tumbles back, crouches in the bush, threads an arrow.

The INSECTS go SILENT. Thunder RUMBLES. She glances up at the Lightning tree. It'll be hit any second.

Finnick stumbles into the clearing by the tree, carrying his trident. He looks around, frantic.

FINNICK
Katniss! Where are you?

In the bush, Katniss takes aim directly at Finnick's head. She hesitates. Her heart is POUNDING.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

All screens show Katniss has a clean shot at Finnick. Snow leans in with anticipation, whispering to her image.

SNOW
Kill him--

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

Finnick looks around, nano-seconds from being skewered.

FINNICK
Katniss, remember who the enemy is!

Katniss blinks. Hesitates. Another RUMBLE of thunder. The bracelet on Finnick's wrist glinting back at her...

Katniss lowers her bow.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Almost holding his breath --

SNOW
Let it fly. Miss Everdeen.
(pause, waiting)
Let - it - fly -

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

Katniss looks up at the lightning tree. Snatches up Beetee's wire, wraps it around her arrow.

She stands, spins, looks up at... The force field FLAW.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Katniss -- defiant -- seems to look right out at Snow. His face falls.

SNOW
No...

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

The CRACKLE that precedes lightning...

Katniss draws her bow, fires at the FLAW just as...

Lightning STRIKES the tree and...

Katniss is zapped off her feet, sent flying and...

Finnick, nearby, is blown off his feet as...

The arrow smashes through the force field and...

The force field shorts out. The false backdrop of the force field is REVEALED, the jungle replaced with all mechanics and engineering of the man-made Arena.

Suddenly everything goes BLACK.

INT. GAMES CONTROL CENTER, PLUTARCH'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Snow gets to his feet, moves to the glass wall and looks down at the control center - he presses a button.

SNOW
Heavensbee!

He scans the control room down below; then urgently.

SNOW (CONT'D)
Plutarch Heavensbee -

Plutarch is gone.

INT. GAMES CONTROL ROOM. NIGHT.

Snow strides into the room, startling everyone.

SNOW
(as cold as ice)
Blow it up, Now! The whole thing.
Kill them all -

The Operator manipulates a holographic console, performs a series of commands.

Nothing. Hits it again. And again.

Abruptly, the power goes out. The room is lit with emergency lights. The hologram of the whole Arena glows before them. The Operator checks a readout, turns.

OPERATOR
Sir? We're on auxiliary. The entire Capitol has lost power.

SNOW
That's not possible.

OPERATOR
I'm getting no response, it's as if I'm locked out--

AN ALARM SOUNDS and now, in the center of the room, the dome of the Arena hologram begins to crumble.

EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

Katniss lies on her back -- dazed, bloodied, scorched.

POV -- The dome roof is dark. A point of light appears. It grows bigger. A shaft of moonlight pierces the Arena.

The dome begins to collapse. The Force Field FLICKERS as it fractures apart, then EXPLODES in a shower of sparks. Glowing pieces of the field break apart and rain down.

The glowing shaft of moonlight grows wider and wider.

Katniss watched the Arena collapse around her. HUMMING.

POV -- Above her, a Hovercraft is lowering, its giant claw reaching out to grab her. She can't run, can't hide.

All she can do is whisper the name of the man she's lost.

KATNISS
Peeta...

And she slumps unconscious, as SOUND goes to

BLACK AND
HUMMING

INT. HOVERCRAFT - DAWN

HUMMING. Katniss opens her eyes. She is somewhere white and spartan. Lying on a wall-mounted cot. She moves her bandaged head painfully, notices her arm is bandaged too.

KATNISS
Peeta?

She sits up. She's still wearing her torn and scorched jumpsuit. Beetee is in a cot next to her, hooked up to various machines. She grabs a nearby syringe, gets out of the bed. Stumbles to the door.

INT. HOVERCRAFT, CORRIDOR - DAY

Katniss creeps down the corridor, scared, clutching the syringe like a dagger. VOICES come from an open door. As she gets close, her face reacts with confusion, terror -- she recognizes these voices. Even trusted them.

PLUTARCH
We can't go to Four.

FINNICK
We've got to try.

HAYMITCH
It's too late. We'd all be killed.

FINNICK
We have to. I promised Annie I'd come back for her. They'll take it out on her. Please!

Katniss is bewildered, furious. Shoves open the door.

INT. HOVERCRAFT, CONTROL ROOM - DAY

Haymitch, Finnick, and Plutarch are at a control console. Out of the front windshield, they are FLYING over a forest. As she enters, they turn, see her, and grin or smile.

HAYMITCH
Morning sweetheart.

Still woozy, she goes for him with the syringe. He catches her wrists, twisting until she drops the syringe.

HAYMITCH (CONT'D)
So, you and a syringe against the Capitol? See, this is why no one lets you make the plans.

He settles her in a chair. Utterly confused, she looks at Finnick (arm bandaged) and Plutarch. Plutarch claps.

PLUTARCH
Well done, my dear. Well done. A bit messy at the end, but we got you out.

He nods to Finnick and Haymitch, She's bewildered. She looks accusingly at Haymitch. He shakes his head.

HAYMITCH
We couldn't tell you. Too risky. Not with Snow watching you. Better for you to know nothing.

She turns to Finnick. He gives her a weary half-smile.

KATNISS
So our alliance? Saving Peeta...?

FINNICK
Only to save you. So you wouldn't run off if he died. Half the tribs were in on it.
(then)
(MORE)

FINNICK (CONT'D)
You were our mission from the start.

She still doesn't get it. Or doesn't want to get it.

PLUTARCH
You're the Mockingjay. While you live, the revolution thrives. We need you in Thirteen now.

She turns to Haymitch, bewildered.

KATNISS
District Thirteen?

He nods. Her anger rises.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Where's Peeta?

HAYMITCH
Still had his tracker in his arm. Johanna cut yours out.

KATNISS
Where's Peeta?

PLUTARCH
He's with Johanna and Enobaria.

She stares at Haymitch, livid. He meets her eyes.

HAYMITCH
In the Capitol.

Beat. Katniss flies at him. Her nails scratch his face. Finnick pulls her off him. Haymitch mops blood from his cheek. Plutarch calmly uncaps a syringe, jabs her arm.

She struggles and resists. Finnick holds her tight. SOUND begins to SLUR. Lights BLUR. We FADE DOWN to...

BLACK

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM, DISTRICT 13 - DAY

Katniss opens her eyes. Someone is at her bedside. She turns. It's Gale. He smiles -- tired, bittersweet.

GALE
Hey, Catnip.

She gazes up at him.

KATNISS
Are we home?

No answer.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Gale?

Still nothing.

KATNISS (CONT'D)
Prim?

GALE
She's alive, so's your mother. I got them out in time.

KATNISS
They're not in 12?

GALE
After the games... they sent in planes.

Katniss starts to break.

KATNISS
They're not in 12?

GALE
Katniss.

KATNISS
Don't.

GALE
Katniss... There is no District 12.

She stares back at him, breaking down.

KATNISS
No--

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END.